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MACT awards ₹1.56 crore to kin of Noida road death victim

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Motor Accident Claims Tribunal (MACT) here has awarded over ₹1.56 crore compensation to the family of a 26-year-old woman who was killed in a road accident in Noida.

Presiding Officer Pooja Aggarwal was hearing a plea filed by the mother and sister of Srishti Sethi against the driver, the owner, and the insurer of the offending car.

According to the claimants, on the evening of October 20, 2023, Sethi was near Sector 62 in Noida, returning home on a motorcycle with her col-

league, Aditya Sharma, when a speeding car hit two other vehicles before crashing into their motorcycle from behind. Sethi died of wounds from the accident on January 2, 2024. The tribunal termed the driving "rash and negligent" in its order.

"It is a settled proposition of law that the petitioners cannot be expected to prove the accident beyond reasonable doubt, and the principle of res ipsa loquitur, i.e., 'the accident speaks for itself', is applicable, which implies that once it has been established in the chargesheet that the accident had taken place, the burden shifts on

the respondents to prove that they were not responsible for the accident, which the respondents have failed to discharge," the order dated April 7 read.

Rejecting the driver's defence that his vehicle was hit by another vehicle and lost balance due to a tyre burst, the tribunal said the plea was unsupported by evidence.

"Except self-serving oral testimony, the respondent did not lead any evidence to prove the involvement of any other vehicle, nor is the existence of such a vehicle mentioned in the chargesheet," the tribunal



observed.

Relying on the eyewitness testimony of Sharma and the chargesheet, the tribunal held that the claimants had

successfully established negligence by the driver and owner of the offending vehicle and entitlement to compensation on the touch-

stone of preponderance of probabilities.

On the issue of causation, the tribunal rejected the contention that the death was unrelated to the accident.

While a doctor testified that the accident was not the "direct cause" of death, the tribunal accepted that it was the "antecedent cause" leading to complications and eventual death, considering Sethi's medical record that showed continuous hospitalisation since the accident till her death.

"... though she may have been discharged in stable condition as per the discharge summaries on record,

no evidence has been brought on record by the Respondents to disbelieve that she remained under treatment as a result of injuries sustained by her in the accident, eventually leading to her death due to post-operative complications like septic shock," the tribunal held.

The tribunal also dismissed the insurer's argument of contributory negligence due to the alleged absence of a helmet, observing that no evidence was led to substantiate the claim.

Sethi was working as an associate project manager at a private firm in Noida, the

tribunal noted while computing compensation. It noted that both her mother and sister were completely financially dependent on her, following the death of her father, and were entitled to compensation.

The tribunal awarded over ₹1.56 crore, inclusive of interest, as compensation to the family of the deceased under various heads, including ₹1.11 crore under loss of dependency.

Since the offending vehicle was insured at the time of the accident, the tribunal held the insurer liable to pay the full compensation amount within 30 days.

Govt approves ₹573 crore hostel project at MAMC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has approved the construction of two new hostel complexes at Maulana Azad Medical College (MAMC), with an estimated cost of ₹573.41 crore, to address rising student intake and a long-standing shortage of accommodation.

The decision was cleared at a meeting of the Expenditure Finance Committee chaired by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta.

The project includes separate hostels for male and female students and is expected to be completed within 36 months. Officials said the move comes in response to growing pressure on existing hostel facilities at the college.

Student intake at MAMC has increased from 150 to 250 in recent years, leading to overcrowding and forcing many students to share rooms. Some students have also been unable to secure hostel accommodation.

The Chief Minister described the project as a necessary step to improve student welfare and academic conditions. She said the government is focused on strengthening infrastructure



in education and ensuring better living facilities for students in public institutions.

The Chief Minister also noted that the current hostels at the college were built between 1965 and 1982 and have aged significantly. The lack of modern facilities and limited capacity has made expansion essential.

According to the approved plan, the hostel for female students will be constructed at Site A at a cost of ₹269.19 crore. The boys' hostel will be built at Site B with an allocation of ₹304.22 crore. Both buildings will include basement structures, along with complete civil and electrical works.

Officials said the project will be developed within the

existing campus, as land for construction is already available. Work is expected to begin within six months after the completion of administrative and financial formalities.

The construction timeline includes six months for planning and 30 months for execution. Authorities said students are likely to benefit immediately after the facilities are completed.

The Chief Minister said the project is designed with a social objective and is not intended for any commercial use. She added that improving residential infrastructure is key to supporting students' academic growth and overall well-being.

The government has iden-

tified expansion of infrastructure in education and healthcare as a priority area. Officials said several long-pending projects are being taken up to meet current demands and improve service delivery.

The Chief Minister also said that the initiative aligns with the broader goal of providing quality facilities in government institutions. She expressed confidence that the new hostels will help strengthen the college's standing as a leading medical institution.

Officials said the addition of modern hostel infrastructure will help ease pressure on existing facilities and create a more conducive environment for students. The new buildings are expected to offer improved amenities and better living conditions. The decision is part of a wider push to upgrade public infrastructure in the city.

Authorities said the focus remains on time-bound implementation to ensure that projects deliver tangible benefits. With the approval now in place, the project moves to the next stage of execution, with departments tasked to initiate the process without delay.

RBL Bank employee held for opening fake account used to siphon cyber fraud money

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police's Crime Branch has arrested a relationship manager at RBL Bank for misusing his position to open a fraudulent bank account using forged documents. The account was subsequently used to route money stolen from multiple victims in a Telegram-based cyber fraud racket that siphoned off several crores of rupees.

The accused, Irshad Malik, 35, a resident of Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh, was arrested on April 10 from outside RBL Bank's New Friends Colony branch, following specific intelligence that he would be present there. He was brought to the Crime Branch office in Dwarka for interrogation after he did not cooperate at the spot.

The case originates from FIR No. 138/23, registered at the Cyber Police Station, Dwarka, on October 10, 2023, on the complaint of Head Constable Sandeep Yadav of Delhi Police. He had reported an unauthorised



debit of ₹88,000 from his SBI account through three fraudulent transactions, made without his consent or OTP.

The amount that was cheated was traced to an RBL Bank account held in the name of a firm called "Lawrie Trade Exim." The case was later transferred to the Crime Branch for investigation.

Investigators found that the account had been fraudulently opened in the name of one Manmohan Singh, using his Aadhaar card, PAN card, and photograph, which had been obtained by a co-accused, Harjinder alias Harji alias Sunny, on the false pretext of arranging a job for him. OTPs were also fraudu-

lently obtained and misused.

An FSL report confirmed that the signatures on the account opening form did not match Manmohan Singh's genuine signatures. CDR analysis established that Singh had never visited Delhi and denied having opened any such account.

Malik, who was working as a relationship manager at RBL Bank's Safdarjung Enclave branch in 2023, admitted during interrogation that he had come into contact with Harjinder there. Harjinder told him he was in the business of opening bank accounts in others' names and routing money through them in exchange

for a commission. Malik agreed. He accepted forged documents and signatures knowing they were fabricated, facilitated the opening of the account, and received commission in return. "He was aware that the said account would be used for illegal activities, including routing of cyber fraud money," according to the DCP, Crime Branch Harsh Indora. The fraud itself operated through social media platforms, including Facebook and Instagram, where victims were lured with advertisements for part-time job opportunities.

They were then added to Telegram groups and instructed to register on specific websites and complete tasks for monetary returns.

Small initial payments were made to build trust. Victims were then pushed to invest larger sums for purchasing electronic goods. Once significant amounts had been collected, the accused blocked victims, deleted the Telegram groups, and shut down the websites.

The Pioneer Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, **Laishram Shantikumar Singh**, a resident of Moirang Thana Leikai, PO & PS Moirang, district Bishnupur, Manipur hereby declare that my son's name **Rioo Laishram** is wrongly recorded as **Leo Laishram**. My son's real name is **Rioo Laishram** and will be used for all future purposes.

PD(851)C
I, **Laishram Shantikumar Singh**, a resident of Moirang Thana Leikai, PO & PS Moirang, district Bishnupur, Manipur hereby declare that my son's name **Daniel Laishram** is wrongly recorded as **Thorin Lashram**. My son's real name is **Daniel Laishram** and will be used for all future purposes.

PD(852)C
I, **Amritanshu S/o Prakash Choudhary** R/o-504A, 2nd Floor, Sec-1, Vaishali, Ghaziabad have changed my name to **Amritanshu Shandilya** for all purposes.

PD(853)C
I, **Nikita W/o Amit Kumar**, R/o K-5/24, Model Town II, Delhi-9, have changed my name to **Nikita Arora**.

PD(854)C
I, **Rita Hira W/o Harbans Hira**, R/o K-5/24, Model Town II, Delhi-9, have changed my name to **Rita Rani**.

PD(855)C

DU makes biometric attendance mandatory for employees

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi University on Sunday issued an order making biometric attendance mandatory for all its employees and warned of strict action in cases of late arrival as part of a renewed push to enforce discipline and improve administrative efficiency.

The university has directed all staff members to mark their attendance through an Aadhaar-based biometric



system. The official working hours have been fixed from 9 am to 5:30 pm, comprising a total of 8 hours and 30

minutes, including a 30-minute lunch break.

Employees have been advised to ideally take their

CM, SPEAKER CONDOLE DEMISE OF SINGER ASHA BHOSLE

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and Delhi Assembly speaker Vijender Gupta on Sunday condoled the demise of iconic singer Asha Bhosle, saying a "golden note" has fallen silent with her passing.

She said Bhosle's demise is an irreparable loss for the world of Indian music. "The golden note of music that connected generations and turned feelings into melody has fallen silent today," the chief minister said in a post on X.

Bhosle, 92, died in Mumbai, a day after she was admitted to Breach Candy Hospital due to a chest infection and exhaustion.

"In Asha Tai's voice, life seemed to smile, each song was a story that crossed beyond time. Her departure is like the end of an era, yet her dedication will always inspire the coming generations," she said.

The Chief Minister prayed for peace for the departed soul and strength for her family and supporters to bear the loss.

Five running cyber fraud racket held

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Five people have been arrested for allegedly operating an interstate cyber fraud syndicate that used mule bank accounts to transfer money across India and abroad, police said on Sunday.

A mule account is opened in the name of an individual who may or may not be aware that it is being used to launder illicit money.

The case was registered on April 4 at the Cyber Police Station in the Outer North district based on multiple complaints received through the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal during a



special drive, Operation "Cyber Hawk 4.0", an official statement said.

Acting on technical inputs, police conducted coordinated raids and apprehended the accused, identified as Rahul (22), Bunty (22), Ankith (19), Salim alias Dhancha (22) and Noore Alam (19), all residents of Narela, it said.

During the investigation, police identified 28 bank

accounts linked to the accused and found 43 complaints connected to these accounts involving an approximate amount of ₹2.31 crore across several states, including Maharashtra, Kerala and Tamil Nadu, it said. According to police, the accused allegedly provided mule bank accounts and SIM cards to other members of the syndicate for commissions ranging between ₹2,500 and ₹5,000 per account.

Police said the money was layered and converted into cryptocurrency, mainly USDT, through online platforms and then routed to foreign handlers via encrypted social media applications.

BJP launches campaign to garner support for Women's Reservation Act

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi BJP's women leaders, including Lok Sabha MPs Kamaljeet Sehrawat and Bansuri Swaraj, on Sunday released a phone number for drumming up support for the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam. In a press conference, they appealed to the people to give a missed call on the number 9667173333 to extend their support to the legislation.

The Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, more commonly known as the Women's Reservation Act, was passed

in 2023. The Union Cabinet is learnt to have cleared a draft bill for amendments to the Women's Reservation Act to raise the number of Lok Sabha seats to 816 with 273 reserved for women and its implementation in the 2029 general elections.

The government has extended the budget session of Parliament, and a special three-day sitting will be held from April 16 to 18, where the amendment bill is expected to be discussed and passed.

Several BJP leaders, including state vice president Yogita Singh, Mahila Morcha in-charge Shyambala,

Morcha general secretary Priyal Bhardwaj and spokesperson Neoma Gupta, were present at the release of the campaign phone number.

Sehrawat stated that Prime Minister Narendra Modi gave the slogan "Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas", and fulfilling that vision, the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam was passed in 2023.

She expressed hope that other political parties would also support the immediate implementation of the amended Act to give enhanced representation to women.



DMRC refurbishing Blue Line trains to enhance passenger safety, comfort

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) has begun a mid-life refurbishment of its oldest Blue Line trains to improve passenger safety, comfort and overall travel experience.

Under the initiative, the DMRC is upgrading its earliest rolling stock (RS-1) trains, many of which were inducted between 2002 and 2007 and have completed nearly two decades in service, it said.

According to the statement, the upgrades are meant to bring these trains in line with current technological and safety standards. A total of 70 trains operating on the Blue and Red lines are being refurbished in phases.

Twelve trains were upgraded in the first phase and 18 in the second. Work on additional trains is set to begin shortly. As many as 22 more Blue Line trains are scheduled to be refurbished by November 2027 in the third phase, the statement said.

DMRC Managing Director Vikas Kumar recently inspected the first train refurbished under the third phase before it was reintroduced into passenger service. The refurbishment includes improvements to both interiors and critical systems. Coaches and driver cabins have been

repainted to address wear and tear, while electrical panels have been upgraded to enhance reliability.

New features such as IP-based passenger announcement and information systems, CCTV cameras and LCD-based dynamic route maps have been installed to provide real-time updates on routes, station arrivals and other travel information.

Safety measures have also been strengthened with the installation of fire detection systems equipped with smoke and heat sensors, it stated, and added that, in addition, older relays and miniature circuit breakers have been replaced with advanced units to ensure smoother and safer operations.

The statement said all coaches of upgraded trains are also being fitted with mobile and laptop charging points, along with new connectors and cables to support the enhanced systems and future upgrades.

रानी अवन्तीबाई लोधी विश्वविद्यालय
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ON-LINE E-TENDER INVITATION
Rani Avanti Bai Lodhi University, Sagar M.P. invites E-tenders for the supply of Electronic Materials through the Government e-Marketplace (GeM). The tender has been issued vide Tender No. GEM/2026/B/7405903 Dated 02.04.2026. Detailed information regarding the tender is available on the official website of Rani Avanti Bai Lodhi University : www.ralvv.mp.gov.in and on <https://lms.gem.gov.in/>.
M.P.Madhyam/125312/2026

REGISTRAR

CM Rekha orders five-year audit of liquor retail units

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta has ordered a detailed audit and cross-verification of the financial records of state-run liquor retail units over the past five years, citing concerns over possible irregularities and unreconciled accounts. The directive targets Government entities involved in liquor sales across the city and mandates a thorough scrutiny of their financial and operational records. Currently, there are around 810 liquor vends in the Capital. The excise commissioner has been directed to submit a report to the finance department within two months. "Commissioner (Excise), shall carry out an independent

cross-verification of sales, stock, and revenue figures reported by the... societies/corporations.... A comprehensive report shall be submitted by the societies/corporations and the Excise department to the Finance department within two months..." the order said. Officials said the move follows indications that accounts in some units were not properly reconciled for long periods, raising the risk of discrepancies and potential loss to public funds. The directive follows cases lodged by the CBI and ED alleging irregularities in the AAP government's Excise Policy 2021. Following this, the policy was scrapped in 2022. The government had then reverted to the old regime,

under which only state-run liquor vends are allowed to operate in the Capital. The Chief Minister made it clear that accountability will be strictly enforced. "Safeguarding public money is our top priority, and there will be zero tolerance for any lapses," she said, warning that action will be taken against those found responsible for any irregularities. Liquor retail operations in Delhi are currently managed by several government bodies, including the Delhi Consumer's Cooperative Wholesale Store, Delhi Tourism and Transportation Development Corporation, Delhi State Civil Supplies Corporation and Delhi State Industrial and Infrastructure Development Corporation.



These agencies operate retail outlets across the city. Under the new directive, all these entities have been asked to carry out a comprehensive reconciliation of their accounts. The exercise will cover sales, purchases, stock

and cash records over the last five years. Each entry is to be verified in detail to ensure accuracy and transparency. Officials said the audit will not be limited to correcting past records. The government also aims to build a stronger

system of financial oversight. This will include stricter monitoring processes and complete validation of accounts to prevent future discrepancies. To strengthen the process, the Excise Department will play a key role. All concerned agencies have been instructed to coordinate closely with the department during the verification exercise. The Excise Commissioner will independently cross-check data related to sales, inventory and revenue to identify any signs of mismanagement. The move signals a push for tighter financial discipline in a sector that contributes significantly to the government's revenue. Officials said ensuring accurate accounting and preventing leakages is essential for

maintaining fiscal stability. The Chief Minister also stressed that negligence or delays in reconciliation will not be accepted. Departments have been told to treat the exercise as a priority and complete it within a fixed timeline. All agencies have been directed to compile a detailed report after completing the audit. The report must include the status of reconciliation, any discrepancies found and the action taken to address them. These reports are to be submitted to the Finance Department within two months. Officials said the findings of the audit could lead to further administrative or legal action if irregularities are established. The government is expected to review the

reports and take necessary steps based on the outcome. The Chief Minister expressed confidence that the exercise will strengthen systems and improve efficiency. She said better financial controls will not only prevent losses but also enhance trust in public institutions. The audit is expected to provide a clearer picture of financial practices in state-run liquor retail units and help plug any gaps that may have gone unnoticed over the years. Delhi's excise revenue for 2025-26 exceeded ₹6,300 crore, marking a 10 per cent increase over the previous year. Following this growth, the Excise Department has set a target of ₹7,200 crore for the next financial year.

Cyber criminal arrested from Arunachal Pradesh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Braving sub-zero temperatures and difficult mountain terrain at a height of 10,000 feet near the Line of Actual Control with China, a Delhi Police team arrested a 24-year-old cyber criminal from Arunachal Pradesh's Tawang on December 31, ending the hunt for a man wanted for defrauding at least 15 people of crores of rupees. The accused, identified as Babidul Khan, also known as Bobby, was the alleged mastermind of an elaborate investment fraud operation that had left victims across Delhi cheated of significant sums. His arrest required a police team to travel to one of the most remote and inhospitable corners of the country, in freezing conditions, during the last hours of the year. Deputy Commissioner of Police, Delhi South-West, Amit Goyal confirmed the operation and described the conditions his team had navigated. "One of our teams reached Arunachal Pradesh's



inaccessible mountains at a height of around 10,000 feet amid freezing temperatures. The team braved these conditions to search for a cyber thug," Goyal said. The DCP added that the police station in Tawang, from where the operation was coordinated, sits just 16 kilometres from the Line of Actual Control with China. The geography of the area presented significant challenges. The terrain is steep, the roads are difficult, and in late December the cold in Tawang is severe. That the team located and apprehended the accused under these conditions makes the operation notable even by

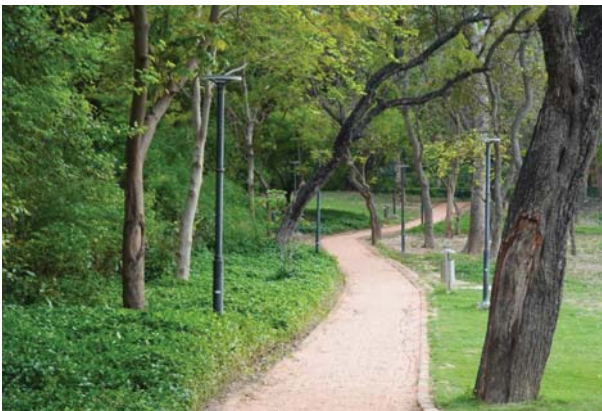
the standards of long-distance cybercrime arrests. Khan had apparently believed that the combination of distance, terrain, and weather made Tawang a safe refuge. He was wrong. Investment fraud operations of the kind Khan allegedly ran follow a familiar pattern. Victims are contacted through social media or messaging platforms, offered high returns on investments, shown initial small gains to build trust, and then pushed to commit larger sums. Once enough money has been collected, the accused vanishes, leaving victims with no way to recover their funds

or trace the perpetrators. Khan is accused of running such a scheme targeting at least 15 individuals, with the total amount cheated running into crores of rupees. The decision to pursue him to Tawang reflects a broader shift in how Delhi Police's cybercrime units are approaching fugitive accused who flee to distant states. Cyber criminals increasingly rely on geography as a shield, moving to remote areas where local infrastructure makes tracking difficult and where they expect pursuit to be unlikely. The Tawang arrest signals that this calculation carries risk. The operation began on December 31. The timing meant the team spent the last day of the year in the mountains of Arunachal Pradesh, working through freezing conditions to locate and secure the accused. Khan was arrested and will face proceedings in Delhi courts in connection with the fraud cases registered against him.

DDA launches Heritage Week celebrations

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) will launch its Heritage Week celebrations on Monday at the historic Mehrauli Archaeological Park with the objective of promoting awareness about Delhi's cultural and architectural heritage among citizens, especially the youth. The DDA's week-long celebration from April 13 to 18 will include a series of activities for students and the public, encouraging participation in heritage appreciation and creative expression, an official statement said. For the first time, the DDA has tied up with MyGov, which is a citizen engagement platform of the Union Government, for an online photography competition under which participants from across the country have been invited to capture and share the beauty of heritage sites of Mehrauli Archaeological Park and upload them on the MyGov portal. The DDA has also partnered with the



Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) for an exhibition/documentation of conservation efforts taken in the Mehrauli area. "To connect students with Delhi and its rich heritage, a number of student-centric activities will be organised at the venue on April 15 and 16, including Heritage Walks for students, Dialogue Competition, Story Writing Competition, Sketching and Drawing Competition," the statement said. To ensure wide participation of schoolchildren, the DDA has written to the Delhi

government's Directorate of Education requesting schools to encourage students to take part in these activities. On April 17, a Public Heritage Walk will be organised to allow citizens to explore the rich historical landscape of the park and gain insights into Delhi's architectural legacy. The celebrations will conclude on April 18, which coincides with International Day for Monuments and Sites, with a prize distribution ceremony, an exhibition of selected works, and a Qawwali Night, providing a cultural finale to the week-

long programme. Through Heritage Week, the DDA aims to foster a deeper connection between citizens and the city's historic spaces while encouraging younger generations to appreciate and preserve Delhi's unique heritage. The restored heritage structures at Mehrauli Archaeological Park were unveiled in October 2023 as part of the Union government's mission to conserve Delhi's rich heritage and its ancient glory, the statement said. The Mehrauli Archaeological Park boasts restored and conserved heritage structures, including Balban's Tomb. It has landscaping and additional greens in and around restored historic structures. Vantage points have been created for a mesmerising view of Qutub Minar from the park. Similarly, Quli Khan Tomb has been restored with intricate interior works. The monuments have been interconnected with pathways, and access has been given to all the 55 heritage structures of the park.

PM Modi to address Nari Shakti programme today

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The National Commission for Women has invited participation from the academic community for a programme on women's empowerment to be addressed by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on April 13. In an official communication issued on April 10, the Commission said the event on "Nari Shakti" will be held at 9 am on Monday. The letter was addressed to the Vice Chancellor of Ambedkar University, Delhi, seeking support to ensure wide participation from students and faculty. According to the communication, the programme aims to celebrate and strengthen the role of women in nation-building. It also seeks to inspire young women to take an active part in shaping a progressive and inclusive society.

The Commission requested the university administration to encourage female students across campuses and departments to attend the programme. It also asked that principals and heads of institutions be requested to facilitate participation. In addition, the letter called for motivating senior faculty members and colleagues to be part of the initiative. The Commission said such participation would help make the programme more meaningful and impactful. Officials noted that the outreach to academic institutions is aimed at ensuring wider engagement among students and educators. The focus is on increasing awareness about women's empowerment and encouraging active involvement in related initiatives. The communication highlighted that the programme is not only a celebration but



also an effort to build a stronger role for women in the country's development. It underlined the importance of participation from educational institutions in achieving this objective. The Commission expressed confidence that support from universities would contribute significantly to the success of the event. It said wider outreach

among students and faculty would help amplify the message of empowerment. The letter also stated that such initiatives are important in promoting the spirit of inclusion and equal participation in society. By involving young women and educators, the programme aims to create a broader impact. Officials said the Commission is working to bring together

THE PROGRAMME AIMS TO CELEBRATE AND STRENGTHEN THE ROLE OF WOMEN IN NATION-BUILDING

different sections of society through such events. The emphasis is on encouraging dialogue, participation, and awareness around issues related to women's roles in development. The programme is expected to see participation from students, educators, and other stakeholders. Institutions have been urged to take proactive steps to ensure representation from their campuses. The Commission reiterated that the success of the programme depends on collective participation. It called for coordinated efforts from educational institutions to promote the initiative.

Friends did not save him: Mother of student who drowned in Noida pit

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Noida

The mother of a 23-year-old student, who died after allegedly drowning in a water-filled pit in Sector 94 here, has accused his son's friends of not attempting to save him and alleged that she was not informed about his death in time. An FIR has been registered against three students, Krish, Himanshu, and Vyas, based on a complaint filed by the deceased's family, police said, adding that further investigation into the case is underway. The deceased, Harshit Bhatt, a final-year Bachelor of Physical Education student at a private university, had gone on a picnic, with three others, to an abandoned construction site within the Sector 126 police station area on Wednesday evening after



their examinations ended, they said. Speaking to reporters at her residence in Ghaziabad, Bhatt's mother, Deepmala, alleged that neither the friends nor the police informed her about her son's death. "When our neighbour called on Harshit's phone, we were told he had met with an accident. Nobody, neither his friends nor the police, informed me about his death," she said. She further claimed that her son's visit to the location

appeared "suspicious" and questioned why his friends took him there. "Why did his friends take him to that specific location? If he had gone there to bathe, they should have stopped him. He was a good swimmer and was about to become a physical education teacher," she alleged. She said that the post-mortem report did not indicate alcohol consumption and claimed that there were multiple injury marks on his body, raising suspicion of foul play.

Government lays foundation stone for community centre in Rohini

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government on Sunday laid the foundation stone for a community centre at Sector 20 in Rohini, to be built in the name of Dr BR Ambedkar, the architect of the Indian Constitution, a project that had been awaited for the past 32 years. The project, announced ahead of Ambedkar's 136th birth anniversary on April 14, will be constructed at an estimated cost of ₹3.62 crore. It is expected to be completed in two years. In addition to the community centre, the government will also beautify Valmiki Park and renovate a sewer line in the area, with an estimated cost of ₹3.61 crore. Addressing a gathering, Delhi Social Welfare Minister Ravinder Indraj



Singh said the initiative is aimed at improving civic facilities for residents, particularly those from weaker sections. Acknowledging that problems related to sewerage and water supply had persisted for years in the area, Singh assured that these would now be resolved as a priority. He also emphasised the need for public participation in development works, assuring that the Government would extend necessary support.

According to a statement, the proposed community centre will be a double-storeyed, air-conditioned building with a hall for social and cultural functions. Provisions will also be made to develop facilities such as an Ahal Canteen and basic healthcare services in the future. The minister said a monitoring mechanism would be put in place to ensure quality construction and timely completion of the project.

Juvenile burglar gets trapped during break-in bid at Ghaziabad clinic

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ghaziabad

A suspected juvenile burglar got trapped between a shutter and a concrete wall while allegedly attempting to rob a clinic in the Indirapuram area here, prompting a several-hour-long rescue operation by the fire department, police said on Sunday. The boy was eventually pulled out from the crevice and is undergoing treatment at a government hospital, they added. The incident occurred early Saturday when the minor reportedly tried to break into a clinic in Abhay Khand by prying open the shutter. However, while attempting to escape, his neck got wedged in the narrow gap between the shutter and the wall, leaving him trapped. After struggling to free himself for a long time, the boy eventually started shouting for



help as desperation set in. Alerted by his cries, local residents informed the fire department. A rescue team reached the spot with specialised equipment and managed to open the shutter after several hours of efforts, safely extracting the boy around 2 pm on Saturday, officials said. Chief Fire Officer Rahul Pal said the youth was handed over to the police and shifted to the combined hospital in Sanjay Nagar in a critical condition.

Doctors attending to him said his condition had deteriorated significantly, and he might not have survived had rescue been delayed by a few more hours. The minor, a native of Bihar and said to be residing in the Khoda police station area, could not specify the exact time of the attempted break-in. Dr Pawan Sharma, who runs the clinic and visits from Delhi three days a week, has not lodged any complaint so far, police said.

Tree plantation campaign turns into public movement

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A citywide tree plantation campaign under the New Delhi Municipal Council gathered strong public participation on Sunday, with officials describing it as a growing people's movement aimed at expanding green cover and promoting environmental responsibility. The drive was led by NDMC Vice Chairman Kuljeet Singh Chahal at a residential area in Gole Market, where local residents joined hands with civic officials to plant saplings as part of a weekly initiative being carried out across the capital. The campaign, titled "Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam," has been drawing support from households across New Delhi. Officials said the initiative seeks to connect citizens emotionally with environmental conservation by



encouraging them to plant trees in the name of their mothers. A large number of residents from the Government Employees Residential Welfare Association in Laxmibai Nagar participated in the plantation drive. RWA representatives and local residents actively took part, turning the event into a community-led effort. Addressing participants, Chahal said the campaign is more than a plantation exercise and reflects a social commitment. He said it encourages people to honour their mothers while fulfilling their responsibility towards nature.

IN FOCUS



A voter shows her ink-marked finger after casting her vote during the Tripura Tribal Areas Autonomous District Council elections in Khowai district, Tripura

PTI

7 held from Arunachal, Assam for links with ULFA (I)

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Seven people were arrested for their alleged connection with the banned militant group ULFA (I), police said on Sunday. The arrests were made from different parts of Assam's Tinsukia district and neighbouring Arunachal Pradesh on the basis of intelligence inputs, they said.

"These individuals were involved in providing logis-

tical support and facilitating communication for the insurgent outfit," a police officer said.

The accused had been active for some time and was part of a local support network, he said.

"All seven accused are currently in police custody, and interrogation is underway. The operation is a part of ongoing efforts to curb insurgent activities in Upper Assam," he added.

UP: 2 dead, 35 injured in bus accident

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow/New Delhi

A bus accident near Ghazipur in Uttar Pradesh on Friday resulted in two deaths and 35 injuries. All the victims were pilgrims from Buldhana in Maharashtra. This is the Lok Sabha constituency of Union Minister of State for Health and AAYUSH (Independent Charge) Prataprao Jadhav.

Upon receiving information about the bus accident, Jadhav immediately discussed with the State and District officials and took stock of the situation. Before he could rush to the spot due to his preoccupations, Jadhav swiftly rushed his personal staff- Private Secretary Dr Gopal Dike and APS Achal Bhatia – to reach Ghazipur Medical College the same night to monitor the situation and take care of the injured.

"They met every injured person in the hospital,



Personal staff of Union Minister Prataprao Jadhav taking stock of the bus accident injured passengers at the district medical college in Ghazipur on Saturday

PIONEER PHOTO

inquired about their condition, and facilitated a conversation with the patients through video calls. I assured all the accident victims that during this time of crisis, my entire team and I stand firmly by their side," Jadhav said. At the same time, the

Minister appreciated the officials and acknowledged the philanthropic role played by his personal staff in times of crisis.

"Our Honourable Minister Prataprao Jadhav is a household name in Buldhana, winning continuously from

there. He was informed about the bus accident near Ghazipur in UP involving pilgrims from his constituency. On receiving the call, he immediately contacted the District Magistrate, Superintendent of Police and health officials

Viksit Bharat blends progress with tradition: Vice President

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The vision of "Viksit Bharat by 2047" is guided by the principle "Vikas Bhi, Virasat Bhi" (progress along with tradition), which emphasises that modern development and preservation of traditions are not contradictory but complementary, Vice President CP Radhakrishnan said on Sunday.

He said that when modern science works in harmony with language, faith and culture, it becomes a powerful force for protection and empowerment.

Speaking at a conference titled "Transformation of Tribal Lives through Science and Technological Interventions – Preserving Language, Faith and Culture", the vice president underlined that tribal com-



munities possess invaluable traditional knowledge that supports biodiversity and sustainable use of forest resources.

"For centuries, these communities have preserved India's ancient culture, faith and civilisational heritage. Tribal areas offer immense potential for green economic development," he said.

He noted that tribal communities have exceptional

skills in design, textiles and colour combinations, which have been preserved over generations.

Highlighting key Government initiatives, the vice president said that under Pradhan Mantri Janjati Adivasi Nyaya Maha Abhiyan, more than 2,400 roads spanning nearly 7,300 kilometres and over 160 bridges have been sanctioned.

Trump orders naval blockade of Strait...

"... but that doesn't matter because they were very unyielding as to the single most important issue and, as I have always said, right from the beginning, and many years ago, IRAN WILL NEVER HAVE A NUCLEAR WEAPON," Trump said.

Since the US and Israel launched the war on Feb 28, it has killed at least 3,000 people in Iran, 2,020 in Lebanon, 23 in Israel and more than a dozen in Gulf Arab states, and caused lasting damage to infrastructure in half a dozen Middle Eastern countries.

Iran's grip on the Strait of Hormuz has largely cut off the Persian Gulf and its oil and gas exports from the global economy, sending energy prices soaring.

(PTI)

PM pushes early rollout of women's reservation...

However, the Act could only be implemented after the delimitation exercise on the basis of the 2027 Census. This means the reservation would not have been enforceable before 2034 under the original law. The proposed amendments to Women's Reservation Act, if passed, will ensure an increase in the number of Lok Sabha seats to 816, of which 273 will be reserved for women.

To implement the Act from the 2029 Lok Sabha elections, changes are needed in the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam; hence, the government is holding a special session to pass the amendments to the law.

The PM wrote that the MPs who contribute to the implementation of the women's quota will always take pride in having been part of this historic effort. "Therefore, we must not let this opportunity pass. Your support for the amendment to implement the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam will be the fulfilment of an important responsibility towards the women of our country. The BJP has also issued a three-line whip to all of its MPs, urging them to remain present in their respective House during the Parliament session starting Thursday.

PM Modi said implementation of the women's reservation Act in 2029 will infuse new energy into India's democratic institutions and strengthen public trust and it will also ensure greater participation and representation in governance. "I am writing this letter so that we may all come together in one voice to pass this amendment," he said. He further said the issue of women's reservation in Parliament and state legislatures has been discussed for decades and in 2023, The prime minister also mentioned the women represent nearly half of the country's population and this was a strong step towards enhancing their participation in the political domain.

BJP set to name new Bihar CM as Nitish...

Nitish, who has just made his foray into the Rajya Sabha, will tender his resignation as CM and then proceed to hand over to Governor Syed Ata Hasnain at the Raj Bhawan.

Sources said by Tuesday late afternoon, the BJP will announce its CM candidate, as by then it will hold ¾ rounds of meetings with its legislators, as well as one with its NDA alliance partners like JD(U), LJP (Paswan), HAM, RLSP and others.

Over the weekend, after Nitish returned from Delhi following his Rajya Sabha oath ceremony, five rounds of meetings were held in both the BJP and JDU, including one with all NDA stakeholders, to reach a consensus on new responsibilities for the first BJP-led government

in Bihar. JD(U) national working president Sanjay Kumar Jha said that the process of formation of a new government was likely to be finalized within the next 24 hours while his party colleague and Minister for Parliamentary Affairs, Vijay Kumar Chaudhary, asserted "the new chief minister will be elected by the NDA, upon the recommendation of the BJP, which has a big role to play". Sources said while the suspense over the BJP's name as CM remains a suspense, in any case, Nitish's son Nishant will be one of the Deputy Chief Ministers as hard bargained by the JDU leadership.

While both, from the Centre as well as Bihar BJP leaders, are tight-lipped about the names, the caste factored leaders are spilling out names which, in any case, have never been met in the BJP, which at last comes out with a surprise factor. Several leaders, including one once considered to be a frontrunner, Deputy CM Samrat Chhaudhary, have been making frantic visits to Delhi recently, and guns are also trained against certain leaders from within the same party. Other than Choudhary, who had joined the BJP less than a decade ago, those whose names are doing the rounds include Union Minister of State for Home Nityanand Rai, State ministers Lakhendra Paswan, Shreyasi Singh, Pramod Kumar Chandravanshi, and Rajya Sabha member Dharmashilla Gupta.

A source in the BJP said that the name of the new Bihar chief minister will be announced after the NDA legislator meeting in the state.

End of an era: Asha Bhosle's timeless...

Irrepressible, effervescent, vivacious. The adjectives were many for the artist who sang almost till the end, and gamely danced too.

Two years ago, she was seen recreating Vicky Kaushal's signature hook step in *Tauba Tauba* at a concert in Dubai. Just as it had been in the years past when she would readily shake a leg in tune with one of her songs.

Dressed in her trademark ivory-gold saree, diamonds and a white rose tucked in her hair, she recently posed for media cameras at Arjun Tendulkar's wedding in what was probably her last public appearance.

Asha got married to Ganpatrao Bhosle in 1949 when she was 16 and later in life married composer RD Burman with whom she had a long, fruitful collaboration — right from *Mera Kuch Samaan* and *Dum Maaro Dum* to *Chura Liya Hai Tumne* and *Nahin, Nahin, Abhi Nahin*. The songlist inspired by cabarets, romance, lament and every other tonality.

"She can sing all kinds of songs very well — sad songs, dance numbers and cabarets. I am not saying this because she is my sister, but it's my duty to speak about her qualities. Looking at the variety of songs she can sing, no singer can match her," Lata Mangeshkar is quoted as saying in the book 'Lata Mangeshkar in Her Own Voice' by Nasreen Munni Kabir.

There was plenty of speculation about the rivalry between the two sisters — both extraordinarily accomplished — but little to substantiate it. "It's wrong to talk of rivalry having spoilt our relationship. We are sisters and neighbours. We talk to each other and eat together. If either of us has a problem, we tell each other," Lata told Kabir. While Lata was the go-to choice for music director Madan Mohan, the master of melody and ghazals, Asha was equally accomplished in that genre, and is still remembered for her ghazals in "Umrao Jaan". She won a National Film award for the movie.

She last lent her voice to Gorillaz's album 'The Mountain' where she sang the track "The Shadowy Light". The song was released on February 27, 2026.

FROM PAGE - 1 PM ramps up attack on TMC

Terming it "the nation's corridor of defence as well as prosperity", Modi said the Centre was working round the clock to strengthen and develop the region on a massive scale, citing the under-construction Sevoke-Rangpo railway line, connecting Sikkim with Siliguri. "The project will strengthen trade and tourism in the region, directly benefiting the youth of Darjeeling," he said. The PM was campaigning for BJP candidates in Jalpaiguri, Darjeeling and Kalimpong districts, where polling will be held in the first phase on April 23. The second phase of polling is on April 29, and the votes will be counted on May 4.

Addressing an election rally at the Kawakhali ground in the northern West Bengal city of Siliguri, he described the TMC as an "anti-tribal, anti-women and anti-youth party". Its appeasement politics have caused untold misery to the state, the PM alleged.

On the TMC's "appeasement politics", the PM alleged that while the Mamata Banerjee government has earmarked Rs 6,000 crore in the state budget for the development of Madrassas, the fund allotted for the entire north Bengal region is "nowhere sufficient".

"The people of Bengal are now seeking answers from the TMC for every moment it spent in power over the last 15 years," Modi said, asserting that when the BJP comes to power, it will make the Mamata Banerjee-led party "pay for its misdeeds". Urging people to vote for a "double-engine" government, Modi said Bengal will witness development at double the speed once the BJP assumes power in the state.

While stating that Bengal has already given the Congress, the Left and the TMC chances to rule the state, Modi urged the people to give the BJP an opportunity to "revive its development trajectory". "Give Modi a chance to ensure the security of the daughters, to save Bengal from infiltrators and to provide jobs to youth within the state. Give Modi a chance to resurrect investment, establish the rule of law, to ensure free healthcare and homes for the poor, to elevate the state from a rule of fear to a climate of trust and rescue Bengal's culture from the TMC's appeasement politics," the PM said.

Modi said the energy he had been witnessing among the people of Bengal has convinced him that the TMC's defeat is certain in the upcoming elections.

TCS suspends staff as Nashik probe deepens

The case has drawn significant attention due to the involvement of TCS, allegations of workplace coercion blending sexual misconduct with religious pressure. Maharashtra's Deputy Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis had then publicly described the incidents as shocking and emphasized that such acts would not be tolerated. The victim Hindu women had submitted written complaints to Nashik Police and accused a group of senior employees, primarily team leads of targeting vulnerable junior colleagues, many of them young Hindu women. It has also been revealed that the Muslim employees of TCS Nashik had created WhatsApp groups and discussed their plans to target vulnerable women. Sources indicated the group allegedly targeted Hindu employees with financial incentives or influence to facilitate conversions.

The victims have alleged that there were repeated inappropriate touching, obscene remarks about physical appearance and personal life, molestation and in some cases, maintaining physical relations under false promises of marriage. Victims alleged that complaints to higher-ups, including the HR department, were ignored. Police investigation has found that the

HR head identified as Nida Khan was complicit and did not pay heed to the repeated complaints.

According to the complaint filed by a male employee, he was coerced into religious practices against his will.

Nashik Police described the complaints as involving a group operating within the workplace. The named accused who have been arrested are: Asif Ansari, Shafi Sheikh, Shah Rukh Qureshi (also referred to as Shahrukh Qureshi), Raza Memon, Tausif Attar and Danish Sheikh. The arrested persons were produced in court and remanded to police custody initially.

The Nashik Police acted on intelligence inputs and registered the first FIR in March 2026, followed by eight more. Police Commissioner Sandeep Karnik supervised the probe, which led to the formation of an SIT headed by ACP Crime, Sandeep Mitke. The team is investigating all aspects, including sexual offences and religious coercion. According to the police, on April 10, 2026, the investigating officer recorded the statement of the company's HR manager, who resides in Pune. Victims had allegedly complained to her earlier, but no action was reportedly taken at the time. She was issued a notice to join the probe further. Police have urged additional victims to come forward via a dedicated WhatsApp number (9923323311) and are examining the full extent of the alleged activities.

Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) broke its silence over the issue confirming the suspensions of the employees under investigation. "TCS has a long-standing zero-tolerance policy towards harassment and coercion of any form. We have always ensured the highest standards of safety and well-being of our employees at the workplace. As soon as we were made aware of the matter in Nashik, we took swift action. The employees under investigation have been suspended pending enquiry. The firm is cooperating with local law enforcement authorities and any further action will be based on the conclusion of this investigation." A TCS spokesperson said. The case has sparked public outrage, protests outside the TCS facility in Nashik and political commentary. Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis praised the police for their quick action and called for stringent punishment for those found guilty. Nitesh Rane, a minister in Fadnavis government, questioned the HR department's inaction and framed the alleged conversions as part of a larger pattern requiring strong legal response.

Social media and public discourse have highlighted concerns about workplace safety in the IT sector, the vulnerability of young employees, and the intersection of professional environments with religious coercion. Some commentators have drawn parallels to "love jihad" or organized grooming, though police are treating the matter as specific criminal allegations under relevant sections of the Indian Penal Code including those related to sexual harassment, assault and hurting religious sentiments.

As of now, no chargesheet has been filed as the SIT is still continuing the investigation. The case underscores ongoing debates about internal complaint mechanisms in corporate India and the need for robust safeguards against all forms of workplace harassment.

Diplomacy fails to deliver US-Iran deal

The Iranian foreign ministry, without elaborating, said the US side resorted to "excessive" and "illegal demands"

The failure to reach an agreement has dimmed the prospect of reopening the Strait of Hormuz to stabilise the global energy market. It is unclear whether the US will resume military operations against Iran.

"We have been at it now for 21 hours. We've had a number of substantive discussions with

the Iranians, that's the good news," Vance said at a press conference before departing from the Pakistani capital.

"The bad news is that we have not reached an agreement and I think that's bad news for Iran much more than it's bad news for the United States of America. But the simple fact is that we need to see an affirmative commitment that they will not seek a nuclear weapon and they will not seek the tools that would enable them to quickly achieve a nuclear weapon," he said.

To a question on Iran's nuclear programme, Vance said the US President Donald Trump's "core goal" is to stop Iran from having nuclear weapons. "We just could not get to a situation where the Iranians would accept our terms," he said. "We leave here with a very simple proposal, a method of understanding that this is our final and best offer. We'll see if the Iranians accept it," Vance said.

The Iranian media reported the talks collapsed after negotiators failed to bridge gaps regarding Iran's nuclear program, control over the Strait of Hormuz, and release of frozen Iranian assets.

In a social media post, Ghalibaf said the Iranian side raised "forward-looking initiatives," but the opposing side "ultimately failed to gain the trust of the Iranian delegation in this round of negotiations." "We consider every mirror to be another method of authority diplomacy, alongside military struggle, for upholding the rights of the Iranian nation, and we will not for a moment cease our efforts to consolidate the achievements of the forty days of Iran's national defence," he said.

The Iranian foreign ministry said the success of the "diplomatic process depends on the seriousness and goodwill of the other side, and refraining from excessive and illegal demands".

Iran's foreign ministry spokesman Esmail Baqaei said issues like the transit through Strait of Hormuz created some hurdles in the talks.

"These talks happened in the aftermath of a 40-day war and in an ambience of mistrust and skepticism," Baqaei said, according to Iran's state-run IRNA news agency. "Naturally, we should have never expected to reach a deal in one session. We will continue to work to bring the two views of Americans and Iranians closer together," he said. Meanwhile, Pakistan Deputy Prime Minister Ishaq Dar said Islamabad will continue to facilitate Iran-US peace talks.

(PTI)

Delhi plans elevated road along Yamuna

The Chief Minister said expanding a modern public transport system remains a top priority to reduce congestion and curb pollution in the capital. She directed officials to ensure timely completion of all projects and resolve bottlenecks without delay. Senior officials, including the Managing Director of Delhi Metro Rail Corporation, attended the meeting. The Chief Minister noted that while most projects are progressing steadily, issues in some stretches are being identified and addressed.

The Chief Minister said several major corridors are targeted for completion by December 2026. These include Krishna Park Extension to Deepali Chowk, Majlis Park to Derawal Nagar, Derawal Nagar to R K Ashram, Tughlakabad to Sangam Vihar, Sangam Vihar to Saket G Block and Saket G Block to Aerocity. These stretches are expected to improve connectivity across key parts of the city.

The Chief Minister said the expansion of metro lines and integrated road networks will strengthen the city's transport backbone. She added that these projects will make commuting faster and more efficient while reducing traffic congestion and pollution levels. Officials have been directed to maintain close coordination and ensure regular monitoring of all works to meet deadlines.

J&K minister urges MEA to repatriate Kuwait accident victims

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Jammu

Jammu and Kashmir tribal affairs minister Javed Ahmad Rana on Sunday urged the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) to expedite all legal and procedural formalities for the early repatriation of the mortal remains of six accident victims from Kuwait.

Six men - five from Poonch and one from Rajouri - were killed in a road accident near Kuwait City on April 8.



Rana visited Bachaianwali village in Surankote area of Poonch on Sunday and expressed condolences to the bereaved families.

The minister assured that every possible effort would be made to provide immediate relief and extend all necessary assistance to the affected families.

He asserted that the Government is committed to supporting them during this toughest period.

Rana also urged the MEA to expedite all necessary legal and procedural formalities to ensure the early repatriation of the mortal remains of the accident victims.

GRAPEVINE

BJP reset post May 4 !

With a complete change in Bihar, the BJP is very hopeful this time to gain West Bengal in the assembly elections. Grapevine has it that the top leadership may consider a 360-degree overhaul of the current States' leaderships'. They will likely make exceptions only for Uttar Pradesh and Maharashtra. The Nitish Kumar reset in politics will also bring changes to current representations in the Union Council of Ministers, both from the BJP and allies. The leadership is keen on reducing the average age of governance, following the adage 'Minimum Government, Maximum Governance'. BJP new gen chief Nitin Nabin has already begun discussions to build a new team before the third year celebrations of Narendra Modi's third tenure begin in June.



Who gave money to Varma

Legal professionals are debating who provided funds to disgraced judge Yashwant Varma. Many are analysing Varma's judgments delivered in favour of certain parties over the past two years in commercial and tax disputes. Several of Varma's decisions have been overturned by the Supreme Court. Others are reviewing the names of frequently appearing lawyers in Varma's judgments. Practising attorneys report that Varma issued around 40-50 favourable rulings in tax and commercial matters. Observers are monitoring whether the Government will initiate action against Varma by directing the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) to conduct an inquiry. Since Varma resigned before impeachment, his immunity has ended, and the Government can file a case concerning the alleged cash-burning event at his official residence.



Internal bickering in Mahila Congress

Mahila Congress national president Alka Lamba and Tamil Nadu unit president Hazeena Sayed quarrelled in Press conference leading to latter's expulsion from the party. Sayed has continued the fight on social media, leaking messages of their spat. Now Alka Lamba issued legal notice for defaming her. No Congress leader is entering as negotiator to end this tussle ongoing for the past 4-5 days. They say initial days those who entered in this mudslinging by women leaders got mud on them from both sides. Better to keep off when pick fights, say veteran leaders.



Amarnath Yatra registration to begin April 15, says LG Sinha



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha announced on Sunday that Shri Amarnath Ji Yatra will commence this year on July 3, 2026 and conclude on Raksha Bandhan, August 28, 2026, spanning a total of 57 days. He said the Pratham Puja, to invoke the blessings of Lord Shiva, will be held on Jyeshtha Purnima, June 29, 2026.

Addressing a press conference in Lok Bhavan, Jammu, the Lieutenant Governor said advance registration for the Yatra will begin on April 15, 2026, via both offline and online modes.

"The registration facility will be available at 554 branches of J&K Bank, Punjab National Bank, State Bank of India, and Yes Bank across the country," the Lieutenant Governor said.

The Lieutenant Governor said the Radio Frequency Identification Device (RFID) will be issued to every registered pilgrim and service provider. Registered pilgrims will receive group accident insurance with the sum assured enhanced to ₹10 lakh per person. Coverage for both accidental and natural deaths of ponies, ₹50,000 per animal, will be provided through the National Livestock Mission.

"Grid power supply will be available along the Baltal Axis up to the Holy Cave and from the Holy Cave to Panjtarni. Yatra tracks will be adequately illuminated. Various e-services and a pre-paid system for hiring ponies, pithoos, palaks, etc. will be available to pilgrims for ease of Yatra. Yatri Niwas facilities will be available at Baltal, Pantha Chowk (Srinagar), Nunwan, and Chanderkote," the Lieutenant Governor said.

Leaders, celebrities pay tribute to Asha Bhosle

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Music lovers across generations mourned the passing of iconic singer Asha Bhosle on Sunday, describing it as the end of an era and recalling how her melodious, versatile voice captivated audiences for decades, with Prime Minister Narendra Modi saying her songs will forever resonate in people's lives.

Glowing tributes poured in for 'Asha tai', as she was affectionately called, from political leaders, members of her film fraternity, sportspersons and people from all walks of life.

President Droupadi Murmu, Vice President CP Radhakrishnan, and several ministers on Sunday paid tributes to legendary singer Asha Bhosle.

"The passing of Asha Bhosle Ji has created a huge void in the world of music. Her legendary career as an iconic singer has defined an era of music in India... She led her life on her own terms as an artist and as an individual... Her music will live forever," President Murmu said, echoing the sentiments of the countless fans of the singer.

In his message on social media, Modi said that Bhosle's extraordinary musical journey, spanning decades, enriched Indian cultural heritage and touched countless hearts across the world.

"Deeply saddened by the passing of Asha Bhosle ji, one of the most iconic and versatile voices India has ever known," he said. Be it her soulful melodies or vibrant compositions, Bhosle's voice carried timeless brilliance. "I will forever cherish the memories of my conversations with her. My condolences to her family, fans and music lovers. She will continue to inspire generations and her songs will forever resonate in people's lives," Modi said.

"Today is a sorrowful day for every Indian, and especially for every music lover like me, as our beloved Asha Bhosle ji is no longer among us," Union Home Minister Amit Shah said. Extending his condolences to her family and admirers, Shah said Asha tai not only carved out a unique identity with her sweet voice and unparalleled talent, but also enriched Indian music further through her melodies.



Through her voice, Asha Bhosle's art will forever remain immortal among people, Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi said.

"Her extraordinary ability to adapt to every genre of music won over every heart. Asha ji, who touched millions of hearts with her voice, left an indelible mark not just in Hindi, Marathi, Bengali, Tamil, Gujarati, and many other languages, but also in folk songs," Shah said. News of the Padma

Vibhushan awardee's demise is heart-wrenching, Union minister Nitin Gadkari said.

"In the passing away of Asha Bhosle, an era of play-back singing comes to an end. An epitome of legendary versatility and grace, her unique style of singing was appreciated by millions across the globe," Congress

president Mallikarjun Kharge said in a social media post.

Vice President CP Radhakrishnan said her versatile voice allowed her to effortlessly transition across genres, mastering soulful ghazals and traditional bhajans. "Her timeless voice and musical legacy will continue to resonate in the hearts of millions and inspire generations to come," Radhakrishnan said.

Members of the film industry recalled their association with Bollywood superstar Shah Rukh Khan, describing her voice as one of the pillars of Indian cinema.

"It's truly sad to learn about Asha tai's passing... her voice has been one of the pillars of Indian cinema and will continue to resonate worldwide for centuries to come. A talent that will outlive many, she always showered me with blessings and love, and I will miss her. Rest in Peace Asha tai... love you," the superstar said. Actor Kajol, one of the many female stars for whom she lent her voice, recalled watching Asha Bhosle record a song when she was 19. Actor and BJP MP Hema

Malini said she shared a deep emotional bond with Bhosle and found it hard to believe that someone so full of life was gone.

"She has made many of my songs so popular with her unique voice and style. I had a very special relationship with both Lata ji and Asha ji, who have contributed in no small measure to my rise in the film industry," she wrote. "It is a huge loss for Maharashtra and for the whole of India that can never be compensated or replaced ever," she said.

Cricketer legend Sachin Tendulkar said it is "a deeply sad day for India, and for music lovers across the world". "For us, Asha Tai was family. Today, words feel too small for the loss we feel. One moment, the heart falls silent, and the next, it drifts through the countless melodies she gifted all of us. It feels as though time itself has paused. Yet through her eternal songs, she will remain timeless forever. "Thank you, Tai, for filling our lives with warmth, grace, and unforgettable music. We will miss you beyond words, Asha Tai."

Kharge demands all-party meet on women's quota after polls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge has conveyed to Prime Minister Narendra Modi that it would be "impossible" to have any useful discussion on the women's quota law without details of delimitation and other aspects, and demanded that an all-party meeting be called on the matter after the current round of State polls are over on April 29.



In his letter to PM Modi, Kharge said that calling Parliament's special sitting

meeting be called to discuss the delimitation issue, which is being linked to the amendments to the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, 2023, after April 29.

Kharge's letter came in response to a missive from the prime minister on the special sitting of Parliament for a discussion on the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam from April 16. "I have just received your letter on the special session of Parliament for a discussion on the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam from the 16th of April," the Leader of the Opposition in

Rajya Sabha said in his letter to Modi dated April 11.

"As you are aware, the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, 2023 was passed by Parliament unanimously in September 2023. At that time, on behalf of the Indian National Congress, I had demanded that this important law should become effective immediately," Kharge said.

Kharge pointed out that, though in his letter, the PM has mentioned that there was a broad consensus for its immediate implementation, he did not implement the same.

BJP appoints Shivraj as observer for Bihar party leader election

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Sunday appointed Union minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan as the central observer for the election of its legislative party leader in Bihar.

With the appointment, the party set in motion the process of the formation of a new Government in Bihar after former chief minister Nitish Kumar moved to the Rajya Sabha.

"The Parliamentary Board of the Bharatiya Janata Party has appointed Shivraj Singh Chouhan, Union Minister for Agriculture and Farmers Welfare and Rural Development, as the Central Observer for the election of the leader of the BJP's legislative party in Bihar," BJP national general secretary Arun Singh said in a notification. Earlier in the day, JD(U) national working president Sanjay Kumar Jha said the process of the formation of the new Government in Bihar will roll out after April 13. Jha was speaking to reporters in Patna shortly after calling on Kumar, the JD(U) supremo, who is expected to step down as the chief minister to make way for a new Government which is likely to be headed by the BJP.

"I think it will roll out after April 13. But you should speak to those who are in



the State Government for more details," said Jha, JD(U) working president and Rajya Sabha MP.

Besides Jha, those who turned up at the chief minister's residence included Deputy Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary and JD(U) leader and the minister for parliamentary affairs, Vikay Kumar Chaudhary.

"The new chief minister will be elected by legislators of the NDA upon the recommendation of the BJP," Choudhary told reporters. "The BJP has an important role to play. It has its own process in these matters. Once it comes forward with its plan, necessary things will follow," he added.

Though Samrat Choudhary is being seen as a likely candidate for the CM's post in Bihar, both the BJP and JD(U) have kept their cards close to their chest. A source in the BJP said that the name of the new Bihar chief minister will be announced after the NDA legislator meeting in the State.

President Murmu on four-day visit to Gujarat and Maharashtra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

President Droupadi Murmu will be on a four-day visit to Gujarat and Maharashtra from Monday, her office has said. She will grace the first convocation ceremony of AIIMS Rajkot on Monday, it said.

On April 14, the President will grace the 'Samajik Samrasta Mahotsava' at Lok Bhavan, Gandhinagar, on the occasion of the birth anniversary of Dr BR Ambedkar, said a statement issued by the Rashtrapati Bhavan.

On the same day, Murmu will also grace the fifth convocation ceremony of Rashtriya Raksha University at Gandhinagar.

The President will grace the second convocation ceremony of AIIMS Nagpur



on April 15.

On the same day, she will grace the valediction ceremony of the 78th batch of Indian Revenue Service (Income Tax) Officer Trainees at the National Academy of

Direct Taxes, Nagpur, the statement said.

On April 16, Murmu will grace the sixth convocation ceremony of Mahatma Gandhi Antarrashtriya Hindi Vishwavidyalaya at Wardha.

PM to attend women's conference ahead of Parliament session

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi will attend a national-level women's conference in New Delhi on Monday ahead of a Parliament sitting during which the proposed amendments to the women's reservation law are expected to be brought for consideration and passage.

The conference, 'Nari Shakti Vandan Sammelan', is being organised to reinforce the commitment towards



greater participation of women in shaping India's development trajectory, an official statement said. It will

also highlight the increasing role of women in governance and leadership across all levels — from panchayats

to Parliament. The conference will underscore the importance of enhanced representation of women in decision-making processes. It will highlight the role of women in the journey towards 'Viksit Bharat 2047', the statement said. It will reflect the Government's continued commitment to women-led development as a central pillar of the vision for 'Viksit Bharat 2047', it said. The programme will witness participation of eminent personalities and

women achievers from diverse fields.

It will bring together representatives from different sectors such as Government, academia, science, sports, entrepreneurship, media, social work and culture.

In September 2023, Parliament passed the 'Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam', commonly known as the Women's Reservation Act, marking a significant step towards enhancing women's representation in legislative bodies.

Naxalism's end transforming villages of Chhattisgarh's Bijapur

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bijapur

The end of Naxalism in Chhattisgarh is ushering in a visible transformation in several villages in Bijapur district, with works under the Niyad Nellanar scheme and the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act giving them first-time access to essential civic infrastructure, an official said on Sunday.

While 224 villages across 67 gram panchayats in Bijapur

district have been covered under Niyad Nellanar initiative through 42 security camps, 1,744 development works have been completed under MGNREGA, generating over five lakh person-days of employment, he said.

"More than 16,000 families have received employment support, with 16,671 job cards registered so far, including 7,271 newly issued cards. Special focus has been placed on vulnerable groups affected by Naxal violence, including 966 surrendered



Naxalites, 178 families of injured victims, and 477 families of those killed, all of whom have been linked to MGNREGA for livelihood support," the official informed.

The arrival of basic amenities such as employment, housing, drinking water, education and livelihood opportunities has reduced migration and strengthened the trust of the villagers in governance after decades of the Maoist menace, he said. Livelihood generation has

also expanded through the sanctioning of 372 'Ajeevika Dabri' livelihood ponds, with beneficiaries in Belnar village of Bhairamgarh block getting help from the fisheries and horticulture departments for fish farming and vegetable cultivation through convergence projects, the official added.

"Housing access has improved significantly under Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana (Rural), with 2,977 beneficiaries sanctioned homes in the Niyad Nellanar region. Of these, 690 permanent houses

have already been completed," he said.

In Dugali village, a newly constructed well under MGNREGA has become the primary water source for more than 100 residents in terrain unsuitable for borewells.

In Palnar, once inaccessible to the administration, construction of a panchayat bhawan, anganwadi centre and gauthan (cow shelter) are underway, employing over 200 workers, the official said.



States Focus



NETAJI KIN CHANDRA BOSE JOINS TMC AHEAD OF BENGAL POLLS

Chandra Bose, grandnephew of Subhas Chandra Bose and a former BJP leader, joined the Trinamool Congress on Sunday, days ahead of the West Bengal assembly elections. Bose joined the ruling party in the presence of State minister BratyaBasu and TMC MP Kirti Azad, and alleged that the BJP indulges in “divisive politics” and does not follow the legendary freedom fighter’s ideals. “It is not possible to follow Netaji’s ideals while being in the BJP,” Chandra Bose asserted.

“Today, we are seeing that the BJP indulges in divisive politics and spreads communal hatred. We must now fight to save India and resist divisive politics,” he said soon after joining the TMC.



ECI TRANSFERS 12 COPS IN POLL-BOUND WEST BENGAL

The Election Commission has transferred 12 officers in Kolkata Police and West Bengal Police in the poll-bound State, officials said.

In the Kolkata Police, several senior officers have been moved out of key positions. DIG, CID Soma Das Mitra has been transferred and posted as Joint Commissioner (Crime), Kolkata Police, they added.

Sudip Sarkar, who was serving as DIG (Personnel), has been brought in as Joint Commissioner (Headquarters), Kolkata Police. DIG, Special Task Force, Debasmita Das has been appointed as Joint Commissioner (Intelligence), Kolkata Police.

TMC, BJP battle to woo women, youth through poll promises

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

The TMC and BJP, through promises made in their respective manifestos for the West Bengal polls, have made it clear that they are fighting to woo the same bloc of voters — women, youth and welfare scheme beneficiaries — even as they seek to shape the contest through different pitches on identity, minorities, polarisation and nationalism.

While Chief Minister



Mamata Banerjee is banking on the social coalition of women, minorities and SC-ST voters that has kept the TMC in power since 2011, the BJP is trying to upend that base through financial aid

Karnataka Congress accepts Abdul Jabbar’s resignation

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bengaluru

Karnataka Congress president DK Shivakumar on Sunday accepted the resignation of party Minority Department chairman K Abdul Jabbar and dissolved the committees constituted under him.

Jabbar announced his resignation on Saturday, a day after a group of Muslim leaders accused members of their own party of “conspiring” to defeat the official candidate in Davanagere South.

In his letter to the party, Jabbar said minority voters and office-bearers are the backbone of the Congress and deserve better.

Later, speaking to reporters, he expressed shock at the party office being used by some minority community leaders as a platform to attack senior leaders from the same community.

Jabbar, an MLC, was an aspirant for the Congress ticket from the Davanagere South Assembly segment.

“K Abdul Jabbar has tendered his resignation from the post of chairman, KPCC Minority Department. The resignation has been accepted, and he stands relieved of the post with immediate effect. Further, the KPCC Minority Department committee stands dissolved with immediate effect,” Shivakumar said in a statement.

A rift surfaced within the Karnataka Congress on



Friday, a day after bypolls to two Assembly constituencies, as a group of Muslim leaders alleged an “internal conspiracy” by some senior party leaders to defeat the official candidate in Davanagere South, where the minority community has a significant presence.

They said the party had named Samarth Mallikarjun as the candidate after considering all factors and taking Muslim leaders into confidence. Despite this, a campaign-allegedly involving some within the party-projected the Congress as having “betrayed” minorities by denying them the ticket.

Chief Whip in the Legislative Council Saleem Ahmed, MLAs Rizwan Arshad and Yasir Ahmed Khan Pathan, MLC Bilkis Bano and other leaders addressed a joint press conference on Friday, alleging an “internal conspiracy”.

Delay in women quota law means delayed justice: Kiren Rijiju

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Union Minister Kiren Rijiju on Sunday told Congress President Mallikarjun Kharge that delaying implementation of the Women’s Reservation Act is nothing but delaying justice to millions of women and asked the principal Opposition party to rise above politics and come forward to support its implementation in 2029 for ‘narishakti’.

In response to Kharge’s letter to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, in which the Congress chief accused the Government of hurrying the implementation of the women’s reservation law for “political mileage”, the Parliamentary Affairs Minister said it is not about politics but about “keeping our promise” to the daughters of India.



“Promises to India’s women cannot become politics of postponement. When it is time to deliver the Women’s Reservation Act, hesitation and questions are being raised. I respectfully differ,” he said.

“This is not about politics. This is about keeping our promise to the daughters of India. Let us rise above hesitation & move forward,

together, for ‘Nari Shakti’, Rijiju wrote to Kharge.

In his letter to the prime minister, Kharge said it would be “impossible” to have any useful discussion on the women’s quota law without details of delimitation and other aspects, and demanded that an all-party meeting be called on the matter after the current round of State polls gets over on April 29.

CM Yogi accuses TMC of pursuing appeasement policies

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Sonamukhi (WB)

Accusing the TMC of pursuing appeasement policies in West Bengal, UP Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Sunday urged people to vote for a “double-engine” Government here to bring in “a truly inclusive regime”.

Addressing a rally in Sonamukhi, Bankura district, Adityanath said Bengal is known as the land of Swami Vivekananda and Ramakrishna, who enriched the country’s spiritual quest.

“But the TMC Government disrespects spiritual icons revered worldwide, posing a threat to the Hindu identity of the State,” he alleged. “Bengal has now become the place of



‘goonda gardi’, which was common in UP nine to ten years back, before the BJP came to power there. There was a lack of development and growth in UP. But see the changes now,” he added.

Adityanath said there is no appeasement in UP, but “inclusive Hinduism”,

where every community can live peacefully in a secure environment.

“Every month, there used to be a curfew. But since 2017, with the BJP in power in UP, there have been no curfews or riots. All mafias have been dealt with in the way they deserve, with zero tolerance.

Centre using women quota to cut Tamil Nadu’s representation in Parliament: Stalin

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Ramanathapuram

Chief Minister MK Stalin on Sunday alleged betrayal of South India by the BJP-led union Government and claimed it attempted to lower representation for Tamil Nadu in Parliament by showing the “women’s reservation” as a reason.

He alleged that the Centre was attempting to penalise States, including Tamil Nadu, that successfully implemented population control programmes and contributed to the nation’s growth.



TN CM MK Stalin interacts with people during an early morning outreach campaign ahead of the State Assembly elections in Ramanathapuram, Tamil Nadu

TN polls: Primary battle between the DMK and TVK, says Vijay

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kanyakumari (Tamil Nadu)

TVK chief Vijay on Sunday reiterated that the primary battle in the April 23 polls to the Tamil Nadu Assembly will be between the ruling DMK and his party, despite the claims of a four-cornered contest in the State.

“It is not 4-cornered or 40-cornered fight. There are only two sides here: One is TVK, the other is DMK. Do you want an anti-people Stalin Government, or Vijay, who loves people? That’s all this election is,” the actor-politician told a massive gathering in Kanyakumari.



The rally, which saw a sea of supporters converge at the venue, also saw Vijay ride a bicycle in the premises, much to the delight of his fans and cadres. Vijay engaged in a cycle ride at his

last campaign venue in Karaikudi, too, as an outreach initiative. But it turned chaotic, with people trying to get closer to him. However, in Kanyakumari, the organisers had cordoned off the

Udhayanidhi slams Palaniswami over politics of prostration

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mannargudi (Tamil Nadu)

In a scathing attack on the AIADMK leadership, Tamil Nadu Deputy Chief Minister Udhayanidhi Stalin on Sunday accused Edappadi K Palaniswami of practising a “politics of prostration”, claiming that he had serially switched allegiances and surrendered State rights to maintain his hold on power.

Udhayanidhi, campaigning for DMK’s Mannargudi candidate and Industries Minister TRB Rajaa, sought to frame the 2026 Assembly election as a battle between “slaves and self-respect”.

“As long as J Jayalalithaa (late AIADMK leader) was



TN Deputy CM and DMK Youth Wing Secretary Udhayanidhi Stalin during a roadshow in support of SDPI candidate from Nannilam constituency Mohamed Mubarak VMS, ahead of the State Assembly elections in Thiruvavur district

there, (he held) her feet. After she died, VK Sasikala’s feet. After she went to jail, TTV Dhinakaran’s feet. Now, he goes to Delhi and says, I will only hang onto Modi’s feet, and he is hanging there.” The Deputy CM claimed that Palaniswami had backstabbed every mentor who aided his political rise, contrasting this with the DMK’s record of standing up for Tamil Nadu’s autonomy against the “Delhi team.”

Responding to the AIADMK chief’s taunts regarding his “lack of experience”, Udhayanidhi retorted that he indeed lacked the “experience” of catching the feet of superiors for posts.

The Budget Session of Parliament has been extended, and a special three-day sitting of the House has been convened from April 16 to 18, during which the ‘Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam’, more commonly known as the Women Reservation Act, will be amended for its implementation in 2029.

The union minister said the Modi Government turned the law into reality and now the necessary amendments linked to delimitation are crucial to ensure that the country’s women get rightful representation before 2029 and it is not pushed further into uncertainty.

He said he has personally reached out, written and engaged with leaders across parties. “Dialogue has happened, and it continues, but at some point, intent must translate into action.”

BJP threatening TMC candidates to gain support, alleges Mamata



West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee during a public rally in support of TMC candidates ahead of the State Assembly elections in Bankura, West Bengal on Sunday

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee on Sunday alleged that the BJP was threatening TMC candidates, including State ministers, seeking their support if the saffron party falls short of the majority mark after the Assembly elections.

She also alleged that the BJP Government at the Centre wants to carry out a delimitation exercise to trifurcate West Bengal, and that parts of the State could be merged with Bihar or Odisha, and it would result in hardships for the Bengalis living in those areas.

Addressing poll rallies at Asansol in Paschim Bardhaman, Chhatna and Onda in Bankura district and Khandagosh in Purba Bardhaman, Banerjee said, “The BJP is threatening TMC candidates, including State ministers, seeking their support if it falls short of the majority mark after the Assembly elections.”

The majority mark in the West Bengal Assembly is 148. The BJP won 77 seats in the 2021 polls. “The BJP is planning to bring in a delimitation bill to divide West Bengal into three parts. It may merge

parts of West Bengal with Bihar or Odisha, and torture Bengalis there,” she said.

Banerjee alleged that the BJP has struck a Rs 1,000-crore deal to unseat the Trinamool Congress from power in the State.

She made the apparent reference to a viral video of Aam Janata Unnayan Party chief Humayun Kabir, who was purportedly heard saying that he was in close touch with BJP leaders, including Suvendu Adhikari, to unseat Banerjee from power and that he received Rs 200 crore as an advance payment of a Rs 1,000-crore deal to split minority votes to defeat the TMC.

Banerjee also alleged that central forces deployed in the State for the upcoming polls were “disrespecting” women in the name of conducting searches. The CM also claimed that she was denied permission to hold a rally despite the venue being available, while quick clearance was given for Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s meeting.

She also accused the BJP of bribing voters before elections, and called the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls the “country’s biggest scam” in recent times.

Addressing an election rally at Paramakudi near here, Stalin said all the democratic forces in the country are all set to oppose this proposal. He alleged: “By showing women’s reservation (proposal to amend the women’s reservation law) as a reason, they are trying to reduce the representation of Tamil Nadu in the Union (Parliament).

They are trying to punish States, including Tamil Nadu, that supported the nation’s growth by controlling the population. Does AIADMK chief Palaniswami have the courage to oppose and ques-

tion this injustice?

The BJP has promised a Uniform Civil Code in West Bengal (which goes to polls in 2-phases on April 23 and 29), and this is a direct challenge to pluralism.

“They are unable to throw this challenge in Tamil Nadu. It is because of the Dravidian great wall that protects Tamil Nadu.” He said the Tamil people will never allow “communal mobs” to occupy the “Tamil fortress” (Tamil Nadu) nurtured by Periyar EV Ramasamy, CN Annadurai and M Karunanidhi, and the BJP has realised this well.

crowd, letting Vijay ride without stumbling inside the crowd.

While addressing the crowd, the TVK chief unveiled a tech-centric “21st-century good governance” agenda, promising to establish India’s first Ministry of Artificial Intelligence if voted to power. He proposed an “AI City” and a dedicated AI University to capture a significant share of the global technology economy, which he estimated would contribute \$1.7 trillion to India by 2035.

Vijay took direct aim at the administrative machinery, promising a “Tamil Nadu

Citizen Privilege Card” for every household to ensure welfare benefits reach doorsteps without middlemen or bribes.

“This isn’t a story like the ones told by Stalin sir; this is scientifically possible. Currently, the system is not ‘good governance,’ it is ‘harassment’. Bribes don’t just stop at the officer; a share goes to the minister. We will break this chain,” he said.

He further pledged to pass a “Right to Service Act” within six months of assuming office and launch a ‘Vettri Tamil Nadu’ Super App to digitise all Government ser-

vices, from ration cards to driving licenses. On the State’s fiscal health, the TVK leader alleged that Tamil Nadu’s debt had crossed Rs 10.5 lakh crore, claiming that more debt was incurred in the last five years than in the previous seven decades. “Every rupee spent on interest is a rupee stolen from your child’s education and your family’s healthcare,” he stated.

Vijay also proposed a “People’s Forum” for digital democracy, where petitions with 5 lakh verified signatures would mandate a formal discussion in the State Legislative Assembly.

LDF files cash-for-vote complaint against UDF candidate Cheriyan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Alappuzha (Kerala)

The LDF has filed a complaint with the Election Commission of India (ECI) alleging that UDF candidate Reji Cheriyan was involved in cash-for-vote practices during the Assembly election campaign in the Kuttanad constituency.

The LDF election committee alleged in its complaint that Cheriyan distributed money both directly and through UPI transactions.

The Kerala Assembly polls were held on April 9, and the results for all 140 constituencies will be declared on May 4.

The LDF is aiming for a third term, the UDF is seeking a comeback, and the NDA hopes to open its account in the State.

LDF leaders said on Sunday that they had also submitted a purported video in this regard to the District Returning Officer and the Chief Electoral Officer, seeking a detailed



probe against the UDF candidate.

Cheriyan contested the election on a Kerala Congress (Joseph) ticket, a constituent of the UDF, and took on sitting MLA Thomas K Thomas of the NCP.

Responding to the allegations, Cheriyan told reporters on Sunday that he was ready to face any probe.

“I will provide a reply with evidence when the authorities seek it based on the complaint,” he said.



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Order Order

Delhi HC to hear on Monday Kejriwal’s plea seeking recusal of judge

The Delhi High Court will on Monday hear a plea by former chief minister Arvind Kejriwal and others discharged in the liquor policy case seeking the recusal of Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma from hearing a CBI petition against the trial court decision. The AAP leader will argue his plea, which will come up for hearing at 2.30 pm, before Justice Sharma.

On April 6, the judge had taken the AAP chief’s application for her recusal on record and listed it for hearing on April 13. Kejriwal has sought the recusal of Justice Sharma, claiming there was a grave, bona fide and reasonable apprehension that the hearing in the matter before her would not be impartial and neutral.

Besides Kejriwal, the applications for recusal of the judge have also been filed by AAP leaders Manish Sisodia and Durgesh Pathak. Other respondents, including Vijay Nair and Arun Ramchandra Pillai, have also filed similar applications.

On February 27, the trial court discharged Kejriwal, Sisodia and 21 others in the excise policy case and pulled up the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), saying its case was wholly unable to survive judicial scrutiny and stood discredited in its entirety.

On March 9, Justice Sharma issued notice to all 23 accused on a CBI plea against their discharge, saying certain observations and findings of the trial court at the stage of framing of charges prima facie appeared erroneous and needed consideration.

She also stayed the trial court’s recommendation on the initiation of departmental action against the CBI’s investigating officer in the liquor policy case.

Later, Chief Justice of Delhi High Court D K Upadhyaya declined Kejriwal’s request to transfer the CBI’s plea from Justice Sharma to another judge and said that a call on recusal has to be taken by the judge concerned.

Kerala HC directs CDB to ensure basic amenities for devotees in all temples it manages

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kochi

The Kerala High Court has directed the Kochin Devaswom Board to ensure basic amenities and facilities for devotees in all the temples that it manages, saying that despite repeated orders in this regard, the Board was giving the least priority to the primary needs of pilgrims.

Deprecating the board’s attitude, a bench of justices Raja Vijayaraghavan V and KV Jayakumar issued comprehensive directions to provide basic amenities to pilgrims and ensure cleanliness at all the 409 shrines, including the Kodungalloor Bhagavathy Temple in Thrissur, that CDB manages.

While issuing the directions, the court said that the Board was duty-



bound to ensure basic facilities, such as a sufficient number of toilets, access to pure drinking water, proper parking facilities for the vehicles of devotees, and a

clean and hygienic environment in and around the temples.

"In spite of repeated directions from this court, it appears that the Board is giving the least priority to



Bring no-fault divorce before marital rape



SEEMA SINDHU

Congress MP Shashi Tharoor introduced a Private Members Bill in Parliament to criminalise marital rape and is building a ground for it. While that’s an ideal thought, the moot question is has the time come? The current socio-legislative position of marriage is not conducive for such an ideal thing.

Before we debate marital rape, we must liberalise divorce and bring gender parity in matrimonial laws. Else the misuse of marital rape will add voluminously to the prevalent misuse of existing matrimonial provisions.

First, we need to have no-fault divorce provision so that divorce can be granted in a short time at invocation of one party without delay in proving fault of the other partner. Right now we don’t have this provision and divorce is granted only on the grounds mentioned in Section 13 of Hindu Marriage Act unless it is by mutual consent which is rare because wives have nearly unilateral legal advantages to delay and

prolong the contested divorce to get their bargain.

Then there’s “teach him/her lesson” mentality. Marriage is the most unequal institution in modern India which needs immediate and radical reforms. While the popular narration is that divorce in India is rising, the burst is that divorce cases are rising but divorce decrees are just one cent in India, lowest in the world. Developed countries have high divorce rates, in USA it’s 46 per cent.

In 1955, we imitated the divorce concept from the West but it’s a right most defeated in the courts. In 1955, socio-economical position of women needed protection. Position of women in society has changed a lot after 70 years and the laws haven’t paced with the change. State is tightening its control over marriage rather than liberalising it.

Toxic marriages help none. Neither the holding partner nor the children who grow with the psychology of “stuck up” and “status quo”. Low divorce rate is not an indicator of happy families. It’s an indication of sadistic State which is indifferent to the chaos marriage has been made by the extreme State control. Assam passed bill to ban polygamy which



in the case of Hindus was banned in 1955 itself. While the move is welcome, shouldn’t the government have first liberalised divorce so that Muslims would have least resistance to this? It’s living in fools’ paradise that marriages are made in heaven. Relationships do turn out wrong and everyone has a right to happen-

ness. Forcing people to live in unhappy marriages is sadistic. It’s State-sponsored misery. Months ago, Punjab & Haryana High Court jailed a man who had remarried during the pendency of appeal, after getting decree of

divorce. A final closure of a case in India can go for a life time, making divorce virtually impossible. Aggrieved party’s whole youth is gone in obtaining divorce. Moreover, besides the legal hurdles, divorce is dependent on the mercy of the judges.

Lawyers know the fate of the case once the matter is listed — judges are known to be liberal and averse without certainty of law. It’s sad that in 21st century one’s personal life is controlled so badly by State and judges. Highest courts have become so keen to indulge in matrimonial matters that Supreme Court looks more like a matrimonial and

bail court, as some judges pointed out. This is starkly REGRESSIVE in the times where we are attaining Constitutional maturity in cases like decriminalisation of same-sex relations (S-377 IPC), striking off adultery (S-497 IPC). Individual liberty is miserably curbed in matrimonial disputes.

When we have constitutionally evolved gender parity in everything else, it is unconstitutional when courts order that unemployed wife can claim maintenance from husband even if she is highly qualified, as Kerala High court observed on 6th December in a matter. Unemployment is the biggest issue in India.

Does the same yardstick apply to wife to give maintenance to highly qualified unemployed husband? These double standards have made the institution of marriage unattractive and oppressive. Recently, SP MP Jaya Bachchan said in an interview that marriage is an outdated institution.

Marriage is a very personal domain and in any advance and constitutional society, State would have the least interference.

The writer is a Supreme Court Lawyer @SeemaSindhu

SC to hear pleas related to WB electoral rolls today

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court is scheduled to hear on Monday a batch of pleas pertaining to the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in poll-bound West Bengal.

As per the apex court’s cause list of April 13, the pleas would be heard by a bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi.

On April 10, the top court had agreed to hear on April 13 a fresh plea along with pending ones challenging the freezing of electoral rolls by the Election Commission ahead of the upcoming assembly polls in West Bengal.

The poll panel has frozen and finalised the electoral rolls on April 9 for the assembly seats which are going to



polls in the first stage. Assembly elections in West Bengal will be held in two phases on April 23 and 29 and votes will be counted on May 4.

The freezing of electoral rolls means that no new person, who has been deleted, can be added to the voters list for this assembly polls.

On Monday, the bench

would also hear the suo motu case related to the ‘gherao’ of seven judicial officers engaged in the SIR exercise in West Bengal’s Malda district.

While hearing the matter on April 6, the top court ordered the National Investigation Agency (NIA) to take over cases related to the ‘gherao’ of seven judicial officers in Malda, observing that

the bureaucracy’s credibility was being lowered and politics was being injected into the West Bengal secretariat and government offices.

The apex court had exercised its plenary power under Article 142 of the Constitution to transfer around 12 cases related to the April 1 incident, as rioting is not a scheduled offence under the NIA Act.

On April 6, the bench noted that around 60 lakh claims and objections of those removed from voters’ lists in the SIR in West Bengal have been decided.

It had asked the Chief Justice of the Calcutta High Court to constitute a three-member panel of former senior judges to frame uniform procedures for 19 tribunals for deciding appeals against deletions from the electoral rolls.

Biggest challenge is limited access to justice, not lack of laws: CJI

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Dehradun

Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on Sunday said that the greatest challenge facing the country’s legal system is not a dearth of laws, but rather the limited access that ordinary citizens have to them.

Emphasising the urgent need to bridge the gap between legal rights and their practical availability, the CJI noted that while India possesses a robust framework of rights and policies, these benefits often fail to reach the needy due to issues of distance, delay, and implementation gaps.

The CJI was addressing a two-day North Zone Regional Conference, titled ‘Justice Beyond Barriers: Rights, Rehabilitation, and Reform for the Most Vulnerable,’ organised jointly by the National Legal Services Authority (NALSA), the Uttarakhand High Court, and the Uttarakhand State Legal Services Authority.

He remarked, “The mere existence of justice is not sufficient. Rather, it must reach the doorstep of every last citizen in a timely manner. The strength of a republic should be measured not by its declared rights, but by the rights that are actually realised.”

Highlighting the unique challenges faced by hilly states like Uttarakhand, the Chief Justice observed that rugged geographical terrain



Chief Justice of India Surya Kant

and limited connectivity infrastructure hinder access to justice. In such regions, it is imperative to make the judicial system more accessible and responsive, tailored to suit local conditions.

Sharing his experiences from various parts of the country, including Ladakh, Srinagar, Nagaland, and Kerala, he noted that citizens often struggle not due to a lack of rights, but due to the absence of accessible platforms through which to claim them.

The CJI observed that the true test of the Constitution lies not in major cases, but in the availability of justice in the daily lives of ordinary citizens, underscoring that the success of institutions would be measured by their effectiveness in delivering justice to those most in need.

He identified legal aid schemes, awareness campaigns, and multi-service camps as effective measures in this regard.

RWA ‘misrepresents’ 1995 SC order on green area cover, lands in trouble

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

An accused in a criminal case moved the Delhi High Court last week for issuance of directions to Delhi Police not to arrest him admitting that he would participate in the investigations against him.

The Delhi High Court bench of Justice Saurabh Banerjee, on April 8, 2026, disposed of the Criminal Writ Petition after he recorded his willingness to make himself available for investigations in Delhi.

The petitioner, fearing arrest, had approached the High Court with prayers for directions to the police to refrain from coercive action and to allow him to join the investigations through a virtual means. However, counsel for the petitioner subsequently assured the High Court that the petitioner, who resides in Singapore, will participate in the criminal investigation whenever required.

Before lodging the FIR, the police conducted a preliminary enquiry. They found that a prima facie case was made out under sections 318, 329, 324, and 61 of BNS 2023, related to the Shakti Cooperative Group Housing



Society in Dwarka Sector 5 in southwest Delhi.

The matter pertains to an FIR lodged by Delhi Police against one Vishal Taneja for misusing the Judgment of the Supreme Court and the Delhi Cooperative Society (DCS) Act and Rules to misappropriate the mandatory green area of the park by creating a passage for the entry and exit of vehicles.

The accused in the FIR, Vishal Taneja, presently posted in Singapore, was President of Shakti CGHS from 2016 to 2021.

While acting as President, Taneja had used a Judgment of the Supreme Court in the RWA Society’s governing council meeting to convert and destroy the mandatory green area of the park into a passage for stilt parking, which was allotted/sold for ₹

Two lakh to its members/residents.

Rather, in the notice for allotment of stilt dated July 12, 2021, it was assured to the member that the stilt offered is technically fit and has reasonable access. A few members of society protested against it. Still, Taneja tactfully convinced the members with a different interpretation, arguing that the Supreme Court’s judgment empowers him to do so.

The members of society believed Taneja, and the common area of society was sold under the guise of stilt parking, with passage through the park.

This vehicular movement through the park led to the park’s destruction. However, after some years, it was revealed that the Managing Committee, headed by Taneja, had misused the Supreme Court’s judgment.

By doing so, he had misled, misguided, and cheated members and residents of society, and had committed a serious breach of their trust. The Judgement used by him actually prohibits the misuse of a mandatory open area, like a park, for any other purpose.

NCLAT to resume hearing on Adani-JAL deal

RANJIT KUMAR SINHA
■ New Delhi

The National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) is expected to continue its hearing this Monday on a petition filed by Vedanta Ltd, challenging the approval of the Adani Group’s ₹14,535 crore resolution plan for Jaiprakash Associates Ltd (JAL). The appellate tribunal, led by Chairperson Justice Ashok Bhushan, began final arguments on Friday following a “priority hearing” directive from the Supreme Court.

The core of the dispute rests on Vedanta’s claim that its bid — valued at approximately ₹17,000 crore — was unfairly bypassed despite being significantly higher in both gross value and Net Present Value (NPV) than Adani’s winning offer. It contended that the Committee of Creditors (CoC) approved Adani’s plan, significantly lower than the liquidation value (₹15,799.53 crores). This implies that CoC would have received better recovery in case it had decided to liquidate the company. In fact, only Vedanta’s plan was higher than the liquidation value.

Vedanta’s counsel argued that the CoC acts in a fiduciary capacity for all stakeholders, including homebuyers and employees. They contend that favouring upfront cash over total recovery adversely affects these groups and contradicts IBC objectives. The legal conflict pits the IBC principle of “value maximisation” against



Anil Agarwal (Left) Gautam Adani (Right)

the “commercial wisdom” of the lenders. Vedanta argues its bid is financially superior, and the CoC used a “flawed evaluation matrix” to favour a lower offer without adequate discussion. Vedanta pointed out that it was the only participant in the five-round challenge process, increasing its bid twice by ₹250 crore. They argue the CoC ultimately approved a plan (Adani’s) that it had initially deemed sub-optimal.

According to Vedanta, the challenge mechanism was inherently unfair. Bidders were only shown the highest NPV after each round, without disclosure of other bid elements, depriving Vedanta of the chance to optimize its upfront cash component — something it claims it was always

willing to do. Vedanta’s central grievance is that the CoC bypassed the standard practice of negotiating with the highest (H1) bidder, opting instead to finalise the lower bid without further engagement.

Vedanta had suo motu enhanced its offer, which was not accepted by the CoC. Conversely, lenders argue that they preferred the Adani bid because it offered higher upfront cash (approximately ₹6,000 crore) and a lower repayment timeline.

Tomorrow’s hearing assumes heightened importance due to a recent out-of-court statement made by JAL’s top leadership. In a surprising move, Jaiprakash Gaur, founder of Jaypee Group, issued a statement on Friday, April 10, 2026, expressing

heartfelt wishes to the Adani group.

The reported statement has come at a time when the matter is sub-judice, and NCLAT is hearing the issue related to transparency of the JAL auction process, which raises eyebrows and immediate concerns.

While the Supreme Court has allowed Adani to proceed for now, it has barred the Monitoring Committee from taking any “major policy decisions” without NCLAT’s permission. If the NCLAT sides with Vedanta, it could trigger a rare “automatic cancellation” of implementation steps already taken. For now, JAL’s vast assets — including 4,000 acres of land and the Greater Noida Formula 1 track — remain in legal limbo.

Editor's
TAKE

Women lead record turnout across States

The high turnout, cutting across regions and social divides, is a powerful reminder that Indian democracy remains vibrant & deeply rooted

On the morning of April 9, the queues began forming before the sun had properly risen. Outside polling booths in Kerala, Assam and Puducherry, people stood quietly, some with umbrellas, others with folded slips of paper, all waiting their turn. It wasn't noisy. This is Indian democracy in action. The Assembly elections underway are drawing huge crowds and voter turnout is setting new records.

No slogans, no spectacle. Just a steady, deliberate presence. By afternoon, the lines hadn't thinned. If anything, they grew longer. By evening, the numbers arrived. Assam had touched 85.91 per cent. Puducherry crossed 91 per cent. Kerala, never far behind its own standards, pushed past 78 per cent. They are just figures on paper, but they carry a certain weight when seen against a world where voters often drift away, disillusioned or indifferent. Women. In groups, alone, sometimes with children in tow. They came early, they waited, and in many places, they outnumbered the men.

It changes something fundamental when participation looks like this. Politics stops being s decided along familiar lines of family or community. It becomes personal. A choice made individually, carried out deliberately.

The reasons behind such turnout are never simple. In Kerala and Puducherry, recent revisions of electoral rolls trimmed out duplicate and ineligible names. On paper, that makes percentages look sharper. But the effect on the ground felt different. There was a certain alertness, even anxiety. When people hear that names might disappear from lists, the act of voting stops being routine. It becomes urgent.

In Assam, that urgency has deeper roots. The long shadow of the National Register of Citizens still lingers. There were reports—quiet, almost understated—of people travelling across districts, even states, just to cast their vote. It is hard to miss what that means. For many, voting is not just participation. It is proof. Of presence. Of belonging. There were disruptions too.

In Kerala, fewer expatriates returned from West Asia this time, the ongoing tensions there making travel uncertain. It could have dented turnout. It didn't, not in any significant way. The booths remained busy. The lines held. By nightfall, the political reactions began to pour in. Every side saw affirmation. The Election Commission of India called it historic. Parties, predictably, read it as endorsement—or a sign of change waiting to happen. But the meaning of that day sits somewhere else, beyond the immediate noise. High turnout doesn't tell you who has won. It tells you something more basic, and perhaps more important—that people still believe the process is worth showing up for. That despite the arguments around institutions, despite the fatigue that often creeps into public life, citizens haven't stepped back. The Indian people have once again showed that they care for their representation. They care for their democracy. They came. They waited. They voted. And in doing so, they left behind a simple, unmistakable message. Indian democracy isn't running on habit. It is being carried, actively and insistently, by those who refuse to give it up.

Reworking Civil Services remuneration

With the constitution of the 8th Pay Commission under Justice Ranjana Desai, India stands at a pivotal moment to rethink how it values its civil services

VK BAHUGUNA

Social media these days is abuzz with speculation about the fitment factor that will determine the salary structure under the 8th Pay Commission for Central government employees and pensioners. The Union Cabinet formally announced the constitution of the 8th Pay Commission on 16th January 2025, but it was notified only on 3rd November 2025. Justice Ranjana Desai was appointed as Chairperson. As India is poised to become a 5 trillion-dollar economy and is at the cusp of becoming a global economic powerhouse, the role of its civil services has never been more critical. The traditional approach of periodic pay revisions has largely focused on ensuring parity with inflation and maintaining broad comparability with private sector benchmarks. While these are necessary, they are no longer sufficient. Today's governance landscape demands a more nuanced, performance-oriented, and future-ready compensation system—one that not only rewards efficiency and integrity but also attracts and retains top talent in public service.

Let us examine the role of this Pay Commission in the context of the aspirations of a changing society and how its principles should be determined differently from previous Pay Commissions. This Commission should reflect a change in approach, considering the avowed aim of our Prime Minister to make India a developed nation by 2047. The Commission's framework of recommendations should essentially be based on the principle of 'Investment in State Capacity' and not only approach it as 'Expenditure on Employees'. The 8th Pay Commission should move beyond the narrow lens of salary correction and adopt a "Total Rewards Framework". This would integrate pay, benefits, work environment, career progression, and recognition into a cohesive system. Compensation should not be viewed merely as monthly pay but as a comprehensive package that reflects the value of public service. The 8th Pay Commission should recommend a hybrid model where compensation is linked to measurable outcomes, peer reviews, and citizen feedback, while removing non-performers and those who manipulate processes for selfish gains. It should broadly emphasise social equity in reducing the gap between minimum and maximum pay, inflation indexing through the fitment factor, and performance-linked incentives.

For services that work with communities, the Commission should recommend a dynamic hardship index that adjusts allowances based on real-time factors such as remoteness, infrastructure deficit, and risk levels. The government should encourage continuous learning and create a cadre of highly skilled professionals, while ensuring

THE 8TH PAY COMMISSION SHOULD BE SEEN NOT JUST AS A TECHNOCRATIC BODY BUT AS A PLATFORM TO RETHINK THE FUTURE OF PUBLIC SERVICE. BY EMBRACING INNOVATION, FLEXIBILITY, AND FAIRNESS, IT CAN BUILD A COMPENSATION SYSTEM THAT IS BOTH EQUITABLE AND INSPIRING

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incentives for acquiring domain knowledge. Most government employees face great hardship in supporting their parents in difficult times, so the definition of family should include self, spouse, and parents—i.e., at least five members in a family, as against the present three-member norm. This shall have a bearing on the determination of minimum salary. It is also in consonance with the Welfare of Parents and Senior Citizens Act, 2007. Healthcare should move towards a cashless, pan-India system with empanelled hospitals, leveraging digital health records. Education support, particularly for postings in remote areas, could include partnerships with quality schools, digital learning platforms, and scholarships.

The 8th Pay Commission should advocate for structured mid-career mobility—both within and outside government, such as in international organisations and academia—as such exposure would bring fresh perspectives into governance and make public service more attractive to younger generations. To further the vision of a truly integrated administrative steel frame, there is a compelling case for reviewing the historical pay differentials that exist between various Group A services. Moving towards a synchronised compensation structure would not only reflect the evolving complexity of specialised cadres but also reinforce the spirit of 'One Government'—ensuring that parity in responsibility is mirrored by parity in emoluments and perks. Aligning the increment structure across all premier services could serve as a catalytic gesture of institutional equity, fostering a more collaborative environment where merit and contribution are recognised through a uniform lens, regardless of the parent cadre. This will help create team spirit within the realms of individual departments' mandates.

As far as pensioners' benefits are concerned, there should be complete parity between pre-Pay Commission and post-Pay Commission

retirees, i.e., pre- and post-2016 retirees. Further, as in Himachal Pradesh, considering the rising health expenses in old age, there should be a 10% increase in basic pension after every five years beyond the age of 65 years. In order to ward off a sudden drop in the living standards of a family after the demise of the head of the family as the sole earner, it is necessary to enhance family pension to 50% of the last pay and introduce a one-time ex gratia of ₹25 lakh for families of officers who died due to service-related hazards (snakebite, wild animal attacks, Naxal violence, etc.). While financial incentives are important, the moral dimension of public service cannot be overlooked. The Commission should explore ways to recognise and reward integrity, ethical conduct, and public trust. Awards, accelerated promotions, and public recognition can reinforce these values. At the same time, strict penalties for misconduct must be enforced to maintain the credibility of the system.

The 8th Pay Commission should be seen not just as a technocratic body but as a platform to rethink the future of public service. By embracing innovation, flexibility, and fairness, it can build a compensation system that is both equitable and inspiring. While the Old Pension Scheme's scrapping has not been welcomed, concerns over sustainability can be addressed through measures such as increasing the retirement age to 65 years and reducing unproductive expenditure at both state and central levels. The country must recognise that forests and their biodiversity are not merely a collection of trees and animals but vital resources essential for sustaining life on Earth. Forest Department officers and staff are performing a great national duty in protecting these life-sustaining resources. However, compared to law-and-order-related duties, their career value is not perceived properly and hence not adequately recognised. "Green Gallantry Medal" awards should be instituted for such officers, with the same financial benefits and ex gratia provisions as police medals.

India's governance machinery needs to be equipped to meet the challenges of the 21st century with competence, commitment, and creativity. Many services have criticised the way the Commission has been constituted, as, barring the Chairperson, there is only one part-time member. The time has come to move from incremental change to transformative reform. Whatever the recommendations of the Commission, the political leadership must be fair, impartial, forward-looking, and innovative, and must promote and draw competence from across the entire gamut of civil services to ensure an effective delivery system.

PIC TALK

Young women perform traditional Assamese Bihu dance during a workshop ahead of the 'Rongali Bihu' festival, at Boko, in Kamrup district, Assam

PHOTO: PTI

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The case for passive euthanasia

APS MALHOTRA

2ND OPINION

In India's evolving dialogue on death with dignity, some lives compel us to pause and reflect—not because of how they ended, but because of how they endured.

One such life is that of Aruna Shanbaug, who was left in a permanent vegetative state after a brutal sexual assault in 1973, at the age of 25. For over four decades, she remained confined to a hospital bed in the very institution where she had once worked. It is such cases—where the probability of recovery is negligible or absent, and where the small, defining experiences that give life its texture are no longer accessible—that compel us to confront difficult questions about the meaning of life itself. In 2011, a journalist-activist approached the Supreme Court in Aruna

Ramchandra Shanbaug v. Union of India (2011), seeking permission for passive euthanasia so that Shanbaug might die with dignity. In a carefully reasoned judgment, the Court rejected the plea.

Yet, in doing so, it marked a turning point: while denying euthanasia in this instance, it formally recognised passive euthanasia as permissible under strict safeguards and judicial oversight.

The next major milestone came with Common Cause v. Union of India (2018), where the Court held

that the right to die with dignity is an intrinsic part of the right to life under Article 21 of the Constitution.

The judgment reaffirmed the legality of passive euthanasia and recognised "living wills" or advance medical directives, enabling individuals to refuse artificial life support in terminal conditions. This cautious recognition has continued to evolve.

More recently, in the case of Harish Rana, a 31-year-old who remained in a vegetative state for thirteen years following a freak accident, the Court permitted passive euthanasia.

The decision reflects a judiciary increasingly willing to confront the difficult reality that prolonged biological existence, in the absence of awareness or the possibility of recovery, calls for compassion, rather than mere continuation. Life, in such circumstances,

cannot be reduced to its indefinite prolongation. Shanbaug's case also reveals another, parallel evolution in Indian law. At the time of her assault, legal recognition of sexual violence was limited in scope.

It was only after the national outrage following the 2012 Delhi gang rape and murder case that the law expanded to acknowledge a broader spectrum of violations. That shift—from silence to recognition—offers a compelling parallel to the present conversation on euthanasia. Both reflect the law's gradual attempt to respond to forms of suffering that are not always easily articulated yet demand acknowledgment.

Against this backdrop, the debate on euthanasia must move beyond rigid binaries—between the sanctity of life on one hand and the right to die on the other. Such formulations fail to capture the complexity of cases where individuals can no longer express choice and where recovery is no longer a possibility. In these situations, the question is less about choosing death and more about recognising the limits of meaningful preservation—and allowing dignity, even in death, to remain central.

The author is a freelancer, writes on social and political issues

A SPECIAL SESSION OR POLITICAL STRATEGY? OPPOSITION RAISES ALARM

A sharp political confrontation is unfolding over the Centre's decision to convene a special session of Parliament from April 16 to 18, ostensibly to address women's reservation. The Congress, led by Mallikarjun Kharge, has rallied the Opposition to challenge what it views as a politically timed move by the Modi government. Mr. Kharge has raised serious concerns about the government attempting to introduce far-reaching constitutional changes during an active election cycle. He has cautioned that any effort to amend the women's reservation framework, alongside proposals to expand the strength of Parliament, could violate the Model Code of Conduct and carry grave consequences. The timing of the session has drawn particular scrutiny. Opposition leaders argue

that pushing such significant reforms without broader consultation suggests legislative haste aimed at securing electoral advantage rather than building consensus on issues that shape the nation's democratic structure. Concerns are especially pronounced among parties from southern and eastern states. They fear that a future delimitation exercise based on population changes could tilt parliamentary representation in favour of northern states, potentially disturbing the delicate federal balance. As the session approaches, what lies ahead is more than a routine parliamentary debate. It is a moment that blends constitutional reform with electoral politics—one that could redefine the contours of representative democracy in India.

BHAGWAN THADANI | MUMBAI

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Democracy at a crossroads

Alndia today presents a troubling picture in the global narrative of democratic backsliding. Its gradual shift toward what many describe as a "hybrid regime" reflects a deeper, more subtle transformation—one not marked by coups or mass arrests, but by the steady use of legal and institutional tools to weaken democratic checks and balances. The harassment of opposition leaders, growing pressure on the media, and the centralisation of executive authority are not isolated developments. Together, they point to a pattern where dissent is increasingly equated with disloyalty, eroding the legitimacy of alternative political voices. Recent concerns around the S.I.R., under which millions of voters are reportedly being flagged as illegal, have only heightened anxieties about electoral integrity. Equally alarming is the Centre's reported stance before the Supreme Court of India on curtailing the Public Interest Litigation mechanism. While the government, represented by Tushar Mehta, argues that PILs burden an already strained judiciary, critics fear such a move would shut the doors of justice on the most vulnerable. Weakening PILs would not merely reduce case load—it risks silencing citizens' ability to hold power accountable. Democracies rarely collapse overnight; they erode gradually, often under the cover of legality.

JANGBAHADUR SINGH | JAMSHEDPUR

Fish, food, and politics in Bengal

Like many Bengalis, I grew up believing no meal is complete without fish. Having lived in Delhi and now Faridabad since 1970, I watch Bengal's election battles from a distance—but this time, the debate feels unusually personal. Fish, a simple staple, has become a political flashpoint. The controversy began when Prime Minister Narendra Modi questioned West Bengal's self-sufficiency in fish. Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee responded sharply, defending the state's record and cautioning against outsiders "lecturing Bengalis" on their food habits. For many, this is no longer about production figures but about identity. The Trinamool Congress has framed it as a cultural issue, suggesting that a change in power could bring restrictions on non-vegetarian food, citing examples from other states. From my own experience in Delhi and Faridabad, access to non-vegetarian food has never been a problem. Yet, temporary bans during festivals like Navratri often feel inconsistent and unfair. Data shows that West Bengal is among India's top fish producers, yet still imports to meet high demand. But beyond numbers, this debate reflects something deeper. For Bengalis, food is not just sustenance—it is culture, memory, and identity. Turning it into a political battleground risks missing that essential truth.

BIDYUT KUMAR CHATTERJEE | FARIDABAD

A call for a just world order

The world today stands at a troubling crossroads, once again highlighting the urgent need for a new global order—one free from domination, exploitation, and coercion among nations. Recent geopolitical developments, including U.S. interventions and escalating tensions in regions like West Asia, underscore how fragile international peace has become. The ongoing conflict involving Iran, marked by military strikes and disruption of global trade routes, has already begun to impact economies worldwide. History offers painful lessons. Countries such as Iraq and Libya were reduced to instability following external interventions, often justified in the name of security but leaving behind long-term devastation. War, while serving strategic or economic interests for some, brings widespread hardship for ordinary people. Equally concerning is the absence of effective global mechanisms to restrain powerful nations from unilateral actions. International institutions appear increasingly inadequate in preventing conflicts or ensuring accountability. Even temporary ceasefires fail to guarantee lasting peace, as mistrust and aggression persist. The time has come for the global community to rethink priorities, strengthen multilateral institutions, and collectively resist policies that endanger humanity. A fair and balanced is essential for survival..

AG RAJMOHAN | ANANTAPUR

No corporate veil: A wake-up call for real estate developers

For years, homebuyers have found themselves trapped in a familiar and frustrating loop—lured by a trusted brand, only to be pushed into a legal maze of shell entities when projects stall or refunds are denied

FIRST
Column



ROHIT
KUMAR
SINGH

For years, one of the biggest frustrations in the housing sector has been the ability of developers to raise money under a large and trusted group name, but shift legal responsibility to thinly capitalised project-specific entities when things go wrong. To the consumer, the developer is one brand, one promise, one relationship. But in court, that same developer often becomes a maze of subsidiaries, holding companies and special-purpose vehicles, each pointing to the other when the time comes to refund money, pay interest, or comply with orders. This corporate layering may be legitimate as a business tool. It helps firms manage projects, organise risk and attract investment. But it becomes deeply problematic when it is used not for efficiency, but for insulation from responsibility. That is where the NCDRC ruling assumes real significance. It tells the market that while the law respects corporate structure, it will NOT allow structure to escape consumer liability.

Housing is not like most other markets. A delayed gadget purchase is an inconvenience; a delayed or derailed home can destroy family finances. For the average middle-class Indian family, a house is the largest investment of a lifetime. It is funded through years of savings, heavy borrowings, and emotional trust. When possession is delayed indefinitely, or refund orders are ignored, the impact is devastating. It is this power imbalance that makes the Ansar ruling so important. The NCDRC has, in effect, indicated that consumer justice cannot be defeated by clever legal packaging. Where entities are closely linked in control and conduct, and where the structure appears to frustrate compliance or obscure accountability, tribunals are justified in looking at the economic reality rather than only the corporate paperwork.

The doctrine of separate legal personality is central to modern business. But it was never meant to serve as a safe house for misconduct. Courts have long recognised that the "corporate veil" can be lifted where the structure is used to per-



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petrate fraud, evade legal obligations, or defeat justice. In the context of real estate, that principle deserves especially careful application. If a parent company enjoys the benefit of brand, control and cash flows, but leaves homebuyers to pursue an underfunded subsidiary for relief, the law cannot remain blind to that arrangement.

Indeed, one reason Indian consumers have often felt helpless is that enforcement has lagged far behind adjudication. This gap between legal victory and actual relief has weakened trust in the system. The NCDRC's ruling helps narrow that gap by putting developers on notice: responsibility cannot be endlessly fragmented. A clean market rewards honest players.

A distorted one rewards those who can delay the longest, layer the deepest and litigate the hardest. By scrutinising opaque corporate structures, the law strengthens fair competition. Developers who meet obligations on time should not be undercut by those who exploit

legal complexity to avoid payment. Far from being anti-business, such rulings are essential to building a more credible and investible housing market.

India has already taken major steps in this direction. RERA was a landmark reform that brought more transparency, escrow discipline and regulatory oversight to real estate. But the sector's legacy problems have not disappeared.

Litigation over stalled projects, delayed possession and non-payment of refunds continues to expose the same structural weakness: consumers still struggle when accountability is buried under layers of incorporation. That is why this moment should not be treated as an isolated case. It should trigger broader reform thinking.

First, disclosure norms need to become stronger. Homebuyers should know clearly which entity is collecting their money, which entity owns the project, what the financial relationship

with the parent group is, and what protections exist if the project company fails. The current opacity benefits only the developer.

Second, non-compliance with refund and compensation orders should invite faster and tougher consequences. In sectors involving retail consumers and life savings, delay cannot remain a viable legal tactic.

Third, regulators should examine whether project-level subsidiaries in real estate need tighter governance norms on capital adequacy, related-party transactions and diversion of funds. Consumer protection cannot rely only on buyers fighting decade-long battles after harm has occurred.

It must also be built into the structure of the market itself. Most importantly, the judiciary and consumer commissions must continue to privilege substance over form. Genuine business structuring should be respected. But arti-

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ficial structuring designed to defeat legitimate consumer claims should be called out for what it is. The NCDRC's Ansar ruling does exactly that. It reassures homebuyers that the law is not helpless before corporate complexity. It reminds developers that branding cannot be centralised while liability is outsourced.

And it sends a larger message to India Inc: legal architecture may organise business, but it cannot be allowed to erase responsibility.

Conclusion

In the end, the message is clear: corporate form cannot outrun moral and legal responsibility. If the housing market is to regain trust, accountability must follow control, not convenience. The NCDRC has signalled a shift toward that principle.

What now matters is consistency—by regulators, courts and developers alike—so that the promise of a home is no longer shadowed by the fear of evasion.

Bharat's reawakening: A Civilisation rises again



R K
PACHNANDA

Bharat is not only a modern nation-state. It is a civilisation with the most ancient, eternal and timeless history and a continuum of cultural ethos that encompasses all walks of life.

Ancient Bharat's educational eminence was epitomised by Takshashila and Nalanda. Takshashila, flourishing from the sixth century BCE at the crossroads of Persian, Greek and Central Asian trade routes, offered instruction in Vedic studies, medicine, mathematics, astronomy, law, philosophy and political science. UNESCO recognises it as a World Heritage Site for its role as a pedagogical centre. Nalanda elevated this model to institutional grandeur. Its vast complex of monasteries, Stupas and libraries housed hundreds of thousands of manuscripts. The Chinese traveller Xuanzang described roughly 10,000 resident students, 2,000 teachers and curricula spanning Buddhist philosophy, Vedanta, logic, grammar, medicine, mathematics and astronomy. Scholars from China, Korea, Japan, Tibet, Indonesia and Central Asia flocked here, creating a trans-Asian academic network sustained by royal patronage.

Both the legendary institutions exemplified Bharat's educational philosophy of the Guru-Shishya Parampara, oral transmission, dialectical inquiry and holistic development, underscoring the subcontinent's extraordinary soft power in the creation and transmission of knowledge.

Bharat's mathematical genius revolutionised global numeracy. The place-value decimal system, with zero formalised by Brahmagupta and conceptualised earlier by Aryabhata as Shunya, enabled efficient arithmetic, algebra and astronomy. Inscribed on the Bakhshali manuscript, this system transformed human computation.

Aryabhata approximated Pi (3.1416), proposed that Earth's rotation causes day-night cycles and computed planetary positions and eclipses through sine tables. Brahmagupta introduced negative numbers, zero-division rules and early gravitational insights. Bhaskara II's Lilavati and Bijaganita advanced calculus precursors and precise eclipse predictions. Together, these developments made Bharat the foremost reference point for mathematical astronomy across West and Central Asia for centuries.

Among Bharat's greatest gifts to humanity

is Yoga, systematised in Patanjali's Yoga Sutras through the eight limbs (Ashtanga): Yama, Niyama, Asana, Pranayama, Pratyahara, Dharana, Dhyana and Samadhi i.e., a comprehensive framework for physical, mental and spiritual well-being.

Ayurveda achieved systematic sophistication through two classical compendia. The Sushruta Samhita details 112 surgical instruments, eight operative techniques and 300 procedures including rhinoplasty, cataract surgery and early caesarean sections, earning Sushruta the title "father of surgery". The Charaka Samhita classified diseases through the Tridosha framework (Vata-Pitta-Kapha), catalogued over 500 drugs and emphasised holistic prevention and medical ethics.

The Sindhu-Saraswati civilisation demonstrated proto-scientific urbanism through standardised brick construction (ratio 4:2:1), calibrated weights and measures and sophisticated hydraulic planning, including covered urban drains connected to individual homes. The Gupta-era Iron Pillar at Delhi (seven metres, six tons) exemplifies metallurgical mastery that still defies corrosion millennia later. From hydraulic engineering to metallurgy, Bharat sustained a long continuum of applied sciences and technological innovation.

Ancient Bharat's global prominence was also economic. Maritime routes across the Arabian Sea and Indian Ocean linked the subcontinent to West Asia, East Africa, Southeast Asia and the Mediterranean. Textiles, spices,

metals and ivory moved outward; religious ideas, scripts, artistic forms and technical knowledge flowed alongside.

This was not mere commerce, it was civilisational interaction.

In governance, the Arthashastra and Dharmashastra treatises reveal sophisticated engagement with taxation, diplomacy, law, administration and welfare. Architecturally, from Mauryan Buddhist Stupas to the cave temples of Ellora, Indian builders foregrounded spiritual depth and technical precision.

The Kailashnath temple at Ellora - the world's largest monolithic rock-cut structure - remains an enduring testament to this proficient skill. Indian aesthetic theory developed a rich vocabulary around emotion and artistic experience, making art not merely ornamental but a mode of knowledge.

Sadly, the Vishvaguru stature that Bharat had held since time immemorial came to a rude halt with the arrival of the British. They eroded our civilisation politically, socially, culturally and economically. Pauperising India, the systematic drain of our wealth to Britain is discussed in Dadabhai Naoroji's book. Handmade Indian goods could not compete

with their European, factory-made counterparts. Indigenous money markets declined and were replaced by a colonial currency system. Agriculture was worst hit.

It is only now, after nearly 200 years of colonial subjugation, that Bharat has assiduously rebuilt its economic foundations and has confidently strengthened its national pride and its pivotal global role. What once seemed like an eclipse of our civilisational potential has now transformed into a determined reawakening with renewed energy and purpose to the path of excellence.

The IMF calls India the "only bright spot in the otherwise dark horizon". We are the fastest-growing economy today. There has been a massive leap in economic reforms, infrastructure, tech-driven Digital Bharat, the ease of doing business, Nari Shakti and an overall surge in every sector, with our nation on course to become a USD 30-35 trillion economy by 2047, with the achievement of a Viksit Bharat.

The last decade has witnessed transformative change: 250 million people lifted out of poverty, GST 2.0 reforms strengthening fiscal foundations and landmark initiatives - Make in India, Atmanirbhar Bharat and production-linked incentive schemes - boosting manufacturing and infrastructure and attracting investment.

On the global stage, Bharat has navigated tariff pressures with strategic aplomb, concluding landmark FTAs with New Zealand, Oman, the UK, the USA and the European Union. Digital public infrastructure anchored by the JAM-Trinity (Jan Dhan-Aadhaar-Mobile), a strong push into AI and the hosting of the AI Summit position Bharat as a future-ready technology leader. NEP 2020 reinforces this vision through curriculum reform, multidisciplinary learning and large-scale skilling.

Bharat's rise is equally a story of civilisational confidence. In ancient times, we were the Vishvaguru; during the Covid-19 pandemic, we were the Vishvamitra (the pharmacy of the world). International Yoga Day, now a vibrant global movement, affirms that Bharat's influence on the world stage remains one of inspiration rather than imposition. In brief, as was reiterated during G-20, the world is looking up to Bharat as a vehicle of growth and development and as a beacon of peace and hope.

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The many lives of India's real Dhurandhar



SAYAN
CHATTERJEE

Not every patriot fights in plain sight. Some speak from podiums. Some march in protest. And some, under the shadow of an empire, disappear behind false names, cross borders in silence, and return not just as men, but as movements. He belonged to that rare last category. He was not merely a freedom fighter in the familiar sense. He was a planner, a risk-taker, a man of discipline, a military organiser, and someone who understood that freedom would never be handed over by an empire out of kindness. It had to be pursued - with courage, strategy, sacrifice, and absolute clarity of purpose.

In simple terms, Dhurandhar means someone who is highly capable, sharp-minded, dependable, and able to carry great responsibility. It is not just about bravery. It is about strength of mind, seriousness of mission, and the ability to act decisively when history demands it.

That is Bose, Netaji Subhash Chandra Bose. One of India's most operationally brilliant sons, also an apt Dhurandhar. Before he became a legend in military uniform, before he became a symbol of resistance, he first became a man who moved in secrecy for the sake of freedom. He travelled under cover names such as Mohammad Ziauddin and Orlando Mazzotta, slipping past British watch and confusing one of the most powerful empires in the world. That alone tells us something important: he was not only bold, but he was also deeply strategic. He did not fight the British only with words. He fought them with planning.

That is why the real story of Netaji is far more vast than this piece of article; it is much bigger than the few familiar images we remember - the military cap, the round glasses, the powerful slogan: "Give me blood, and I will give you freedom." That line still stirs the heart, but Netaji was much more than a powerful speaker. He was a man of action, and in many ways, one of the sharpest political minds of India's freedom struggle.

Among the many remarkable chapters of Netaji Subhash Chandra Bose's life, few are as gripping as the moments when he chose to vanish into the shadows so that India's hope could remain alive. In 1941, when the British believed they had him cornered under strict surveillance at his Calcutta residence, Bose quietly slipped away right under their noses. Disguised as a Pathan or Afghan traveller and using the name Mohammad Ziauddin, he carried not only a false identity but also the burden of a nation

still waiting to be free.

His journey through Peshawar and Kabul unfolded in a world thick with danger - spies, double agents, embassy manoeuvring, and the paranoia of war. This was far more than an escape. It was an act of immense courage, sharp planning, and extraordinary composure under pressure.

As his mission carried him deeper into wartime Europe, another name became linked to his secret movement: Orlando Mazzotta. It was yet another borrowed identity in a life that had willingly embraced risk for a cause far greater than personal safety. After weeks of uncertainty in Afghanistan and unsuccessful efforts to secure Soviet support, Bose was eventually able to move forward under this Italian identity - often described as that of an Italian diplomat and radio operator. Over time, Orlando Mazzotta came to be remembered as one of the most fascinating aliases in Netaji's covert journey across continents.

Under this cover, Bose went on to undertake one of the boldest and least spoken-about missions of India's freedom struggle. In 1943, he travelled nearly 18,000 kilometres through perilous wartime waters aboard the German submarine U-180, before making a dramatic mid-ocean transfer near Madagascar to the Japanese submarine I-29. It was the kind of journey that feels less like political history and more like a wartime thriller. By then, Bose had already outwitted British surveillance in India through disguise, secrecy, and astonishing nerve. But he was not done. He was determined to reach East Asia

and build a military front against the British Raj. Through rough seas, hostile territory, and constant threat, he is said to have remained calm, disciplined, and unwavering - reportedly even dictating instructions in the midst of grave danger.

And yet, beneath every disguise, every changed route, and every assumed name, the man himself never changed. The face may have been altered. The passport may have been different. But the mission remained the same. Behind Mohammad Ziauddin and Orlando Mazzotta stood the same unyielding spirit - Netaji, moving through silence, shadows, and immense risk, so that one day India could walk towards freedom in the light. Netaji understood something very important: an empire is not defeated only by emotion or moral anger. It is defeated when it is challenged from every side - politically, psychologically, and strategically.

Please read the complete article online at
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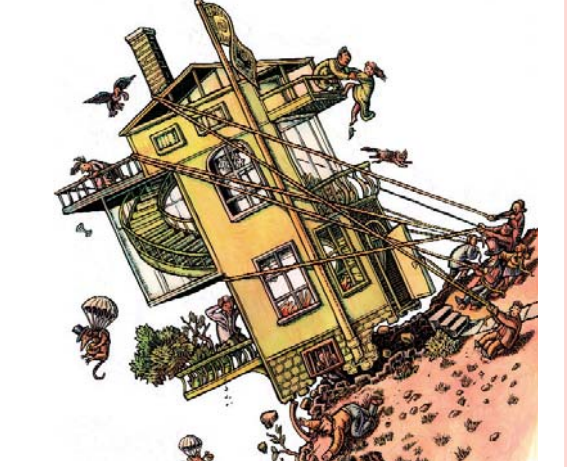
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DOLLAR RECLINES



Several news items, trends, and insights concluded that the importance of the dollar is on the decline, even as the currency gains strength against the others due to the ongoing Iran war. Two recent events are of great significance in such an analysis. For the first time since the mid-1990s, the gold reserves of central banks surpassed their holdings in the US treasuries, \$4 trillion against \$3.9 trillion, respectively.

According to media reports, one of the criteria that Iran has posed for a ceasefire is payment, either in Chinese yuan or crypto, for tankers to pass through the Strait of Hormuz.

Both hint at the trends that can undermine the dollar in the future, as were initiatives such as BRICS' efforts to trade in non-dollar currencies, or bilateral efforts to bypass the American currency. Although both the recent headlines are riddled with a few holes, and past actions did not sail, if they did not fail, the dollar and America are in for some interesting times in the future.

Over the past decade, the share of the US treasuries in the central banks' reserves declined steadily, and ominously, from 33 per cent to 21 per cent. One can pinpoint several long-term macro factors for this trend. The first is obviously the looming US debt, which is \$38 trillion, counting, and ever-growing. This intensifies the so-called 'debasement effect,' as investors feel that in the long run, the currency will devalue, even if it is on a temporary rise at the present. Given the high American fiscal deficits, and despite the moves to manage them, there is the urge to increase the money supply.

This erodes a currency's underlying purchasing power over time, whatever may be its visible strength. Geopolitics, politics, economics, and business have forced nations and firms to wean away from the dollar. China and Russia do not wish to trade in dollars, or own dollar assets, if they can avoid them. The thinking is the same among the Europeans, who wanted to replace the dollar's dominance with the Euro at least for the past two decades.

Iran's attempts to take money in yuan or crypto is a step in the same direction, and on the same path and journey. According to a media report, the rise of the dollar began in 1974, when the US treasury secretary met the Saudi King, and chalked up a grand strategic plan.

If the Saudi, then among the major oil producers, traded each barrel in dollars, the US would protect the regime. "Smart geopolitics was scaffolded by smart economics, global demand for oil, and global pricing in dollars entrenched the domination of the dollar," states the report. It was no coincidence that 1973 marked the first oil shock in modern history. Today, the two of the largest oil consumers, India and China, buy oil in non-dollar currencies.

China pays in yuan to Russia, Iran and Saudi Arabia. India pays Russia, which emerged as the largest seller in the recent past, often in rupees. The focus on petrodollars, which revolutionised the banking and financial systems since the 1970s, has shifted to petro-yuan, petro-rupees, and others.

But let us not get carried away. As far as gold versus treasuries is concerned, one of the major reasons for the ascent of the former is the unexpected boom in prices, which went up 70 per cent in 2025, and have since corrected sharply.

This boosted the values of the central banks' gold reserves without them having to do anything, although they regularly purchased 1,000 tonnes a year between 2022 and 2024.

Thus, there was a bit of coincidence in the gold surge against the treasuries. In addition, most central banks, including the Indian one, shifted their gold reserves from America to their own countries. One need not forget that gold is not usually traded by the central banks, and the bullion is not a mode of payments among nations, and businesses. Dollar and currencies are. In this respect, the dollar does enjoy an advantage. The fact remains that gold is not a currency, only a hedge, or an asset.

On the crude oil front, petrodollars will remain prominent, especially now, even as Iran, Russia, China, and India shift towards yuan and rupees. After the Iran crisis ends, whichever way it is resolved, and it will be sooner than later, the Middle East may be keener to deal in dollars.

The conflict shows what Iran, and others, can do in West Asia, and how they can disrupt businesses and economies within days and weeks. The Strait of Hormuz and Red Sea, and other choke points will invariably be at risk from some one or the other.

This will push the Middle East closer to the US, rather than Russia or China. The latter two will make inroads but not dent the dollar citadel. More oil will be traded in dollars, especially by the sellers in West Asia. Once this happens, other buyers, and even sellers will follow suit, even as the US takes over the oil supplies from Venezuela, and increases oil exports from its sources. In essence, America's dominance over oil may increase. Dollar's prominence may shoot up, at least temporarily.

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | MONDAY | APRIL 13, 2026



BUSINESS10

Myths, phobia, Anthropic Mythos

After a \$2 trillion pre-war software crash, banks may be in trouble

Not too long ago, before the Iran war, the Claude versions of the AI-giant, Anthropic, wiped out a couple of trillion dollars from tech firms. The Tsunami waves hit the Indian shores, as IT firms lost valuations that were unbelievable, despite the rapid declines in 2025. Now, the main competitor of ChatGPT has frightened major banks, and stocks of leading cybersecurity firms. The details about the mythical 'Claude Mythos Preview' prompted an urgent, emergency meeting between the Federal Reserve Chair, US treasury secretary, and CEOs from leading names such as Bank of America, Goldman Sachs, and Citigroup.

Mythos, like a mythological virtual tool, can find flaws in software, operating systems, and web browsers that may be hidden for decades. It found one that was 27 years old, and another, which was 16 years old, and had evaded detection in five million automated tests. In a jiffy, the new, experimental AI model questioned the cybersecurity measures across sectors, systems, and especially financial networks. Big banks have consistently highlighted this area as the biggest risk, as AI emerges as a huge threat that will require better defense. Although Mythos may do the latter work, it points to former dangers.

The scare is potent despite Claude's stance that the project or tool will not be made public, access will be strictly controlled, and through Project Glasswing, it will collaborate with tech giants such as Amazon, Google, Apple, Cisco, Microsoft, Nvidia, and Linux. The project will quietly, and mostly invisibly, scan critical software, and secure them against possible cyber attacks in the future. But no one is getting fooled. If Anthropic can develop it, so can others. In fact, there is a chat that competitor ChatGPT has a similar model. An AI security firm claimed smaller,

cheaper models with the same capabilities can crop up.

Experts feel that the threat is overblown. Yann LeCun, former chief AI scientist, Meta, dismissed the panic as an "overblown theatrics." His non-technical equation is, 'Mythos drama = BS from self-delusion.' Another AI researcher wrote that "we were played." Such experts think that the Mythos version is only 'incrementally better' than its predecessors, and is not a breakthrough. While they agree with the risks, they cannot "ignore that Anthropic has a history of scare tactics." The AI giant is a "little ahead" of competition, but not "overwhelmingly ahead." But how much time before the latter turns out to be true?

However, this is aided with the financial incentives, and goodies that may land in Anthropic's lap because of the Mythos exposure. According to media reports, the AI firm has tripled annual revenues to more than \$30 billion, and is ready for a massive IPO (Initial Public Offering). So is OpenAI with its ChatGPT tools. Hence, there is an investment, stock-listing race between the two. Although it will not matter, egos will tussle to get bigger and better valuations, and list early. "A model too dangerous to release, available only to the world's largest corporations, that reads as easily as a safety decision as it does a sales pitch," states a tongue-in-cheek, sarcastic, and cheeky media report.

Like it or not, the debate will continue until the next major cyberattack on a network or browser under Mythos' radar, or until the fear recedes, and then dies down as most scares do. Still, many tech firms are willing to treat the new Claude version as the real thing, or "genuine inflexion point." One of the CEOs, whose firm is

a part of Project Glasswing, said that "what once took months now happens in minutes with AI." A chief security officer dubbed it a "threshold moment with 'no going back.'" Obviously, these firms are running scared.

Their systems, defensive measures, and cybersecurity tools may be in disarray. They have reputations to protect. They will not take chances, and leave no stone unturned, especially when the tool developer is willing to cooperate and collaborate. If Mythos can spot something, let us go with it. If it cannot, so be it, and it does not matter. It is a small investment compared to what it claims to protect. It is worth the while. As we mentioned earlier, there is no guarantee of what the other firms may do in the future, what they may develop, and sell publicly.

At present, experts are still trying to assess the contours of reality. "The gap between what Anthropic has shown, and what independent observers can verify is the central tension.... A model that can autonomously generate exploits for hardened systems... would represent a genuine shift in the balance between attackers and defenders. If the capability is as described, the decision to withhold public release is defensible on safety grounds. But the AI industry has a pattern of making dramatic capability claims that later prove narrower than initially presented, and the absence of third-party validation leaves room for skepticism," states a media report.

For many observers, as we mentioned, it depends on what will happen if the same capability lands in different hands. If the attackers gain access via leaks, thefts, mistakes, insiders, and what not, how will one assess the future damage, and who will one blame. In essence, attackers can develop their own versions which, even if not this successful, may be able to spot weak points in some systems and browsers. In fact, Mythos may enthuse and encourage them to work harder. They know that someone has done it, and so it can be done.

"Several developments will determine how this story evolves. First, independent validation: If trusted third-party security teams are finally allowed to publish... results from their own testing of Mythos Preview, that could either bolster or temper Anthropic's claims. Second, partner transparency: Statements... would clarify how tightly access is controlled, and what oversight mechanisms are in place. Third, policy response bears watching. Governments and standard bodies may use cases like Mythos Preview to argue for mandatory disclosure regimes, licensing frameworks, or safety evaluations for AI systems with significant cyber capabilities," explains a media report. These will need to balance innovation with extreme risk mitigation.

Hence, there are several sides and angles to the story. It is not a simple case of a tool that may or will shatter a specific segment of the tech business universe, as was the case with the decimation of the values of enterprise software firms not too long ago. This includes notions about hype, seclusion, sharing, access, and abilities.

OUR TAKE

The Tech Wrecker

The invisible deep fake heist

The big question is whether India is AI-crime-proof or not?

we have the 2FA, or two-factor authentication. These systems assume that frauds occur when credentials are compromised. AI-led fraud bypasses this as they target personalities rather than access to their systems. In most reported incidents, there are no breaches in the conventional sense. The users are persuaded. OTPs are shared, links are clicked, or transactions are approved because the requests appear legitimate.

Banking executives have increasingly pointed to impersonation-led frauds as higher-conversion channels than generic phishing, particularly across remote transaction environments such as UPI and card-not-present payments. The system fails not because it is technically broken, but because it is operating at the wrong layer. This is most visible in the reliance on OTP-based authentication. Even the 2FA, or OTP-plus regime may not help. OTP assumes that possession of a registered device validates identity. This is weakened through multiple vectors: SIM swap fraud that redirects messages, call spoofing that mimics legitimate institutions, and AI-assisted interactions that convince users to disclose verification codes voluntarily.

As is evident from the Parliament report, the 2FA may not work, as AI systems are deployed to bypass the multi-factor authentication frameworks, effectively turning the primary defense mechanism into a target. The structure of frauds has shifted from the individual actors to organised operations. A significant share of India's high-value scams,

including the so-called "digital arrest" cases, are traced to coordinated centres operating outside the country, particularly in parts of Southeast Asia. These are not loosely organised networks but structured operations with defined workflows, performance tracking, and access to shared technological infrastructure.

Globally, fraud-as-a-service ecosystems offer modular tools ranging from phishing kits to synthetic identity frameworks at subscription-level pricing, lowering entry barriers for new operators. Within India, this development is reflected in the composition of losses. Investment scams account for a disproportionately high share of financial damage, while identity-driven fraud continues to expand across retail and corporate segments. The scale of activity suggests that frauds are no longer episodic but systemic, embedded within the broader digital transaction ecosystem. However, the infrastructure through which this operates is fragmented. Banking systems enable fund transfers, telecom networks control communication channels, and digital platforms provide entry points for engagement.

Each layer is regulated independently, while fraud cuts across all three simultaneously. This fragmentation creates delays in detection and response, even as attackers operate in real time. India has built mechanisms to address parts of this problem.

The Citizen Financial Cybercrime Reporting and Management System has enabled the blocking of over ₹8,000 crore in fraudulent transactions through coordinated action across banks and payment platforms. Machine learning systems like Mule-Hunter are being developed to identify suspicious accounts based on transaction patterns.

These are meaningful interventions, but they remain largely reactive. Funds are frozen after detection, and patterns are identified after repetition. AI-led fraud compresses execution cycles to minutes, reduc-

ing the window available for intervention. The risk is extending beyond retail users to corporate systems. Business email compromise, historically dependent on text-based impersonation, is being replaced by audio-visual deception. Documented global cases involving deep fake video calls have resulted in multi-million-dollar losses. In India, the rise in voice cloning incidents, and AI-driven impersonation scams indicates that similar vulnerabilities are emerging within enterprise workflows.

Verification methods that rely on voice confirmation or video calls are no longer reliable when both can be synthetically reproduced. The legal and regulatory framework has begun to adapt but remains uneven in its coverage. Recent changes introduced provisions to address organised cybercrime and synthetic content, while updated IT rules impose tighter timelines for content take-downs. The Digital Personal Data Protection framework adds obligations around data handling and breach disclosure.

However, three structural constraints persist: difficulty of attributing AI-generated fraud across jurisdictions, lag between fraud execution and legal response, and transnational nature of many organised operations targeting Indian users.

What emerges from this is not a failure of components but a gap in alignment. Digital adoption expands the base over which fraud operates. AI reduces costs, and increases effectiveness. Defensive systems, while improving, are not calibrated to the same speed or coordination. Real-time deepfake impersonations will become standard in high-value frauds. AI-driven phishing will make it difficult to distinguish from legitimate interaction. More significantly, agentic systems can execute multi-step fraud operations with minimal human oversight, from target identification to fund extraction. In that context, the shift is not simply an increase in fraud volume. It is a change in how fraud is executed. The transition from credential theft to personality manipulation alters the definition of security. Systems built to protect access are increasingly ineffective against systems designed to manipulate intent. India's digital infrastructure has scaled faster than most nations. The challenge is whether its security design and architecture can adapt at a comparable pace.

The Pioneer

SINCE 1865

FROM THE WORLD

PAKISTAN

Soldier killed in IED blast

At least one security personnel was killed and five others injured in a blast near a security checkpoint in Pakistan's northwestern Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province, police said on Sunday. According to police, unidentified militants detonated an improvised explosive device (IED) near a checkpoint adjacent to a degree college in Bannu district late Thursday. One soldier was killed on the spot, while five others, including a civilian, sustained injuries. Security forces immediately cordoned off the area and launched a search operation to apprehend those responsible for the blast. The injured were shifted to a nearby hospital for medical treatment, officials confirmed. In a separate incident, a policeman was abducted and later killed by militants in the Hassan Khel area, located approximately 30 kilometres southwest of Peshawar.

UAE

EAM meets UAE Dy PM

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar met UAE Deputy Prime Minister and Foreign Minister Abdullah bin Zayed Al Nahyan in Abu Dhabi and discussed the evolving regional situation and its implications. Jaishankar is in Abu Dhabi in the concluding leg of his four-day two-nation visit to Mauritius and the UAE from April 9-12. "A real pleasure to meet DPM & FM @ABZayed of UAE in Abu Dhabi this evening. Our conversation focused on the evolving regional situation and its implications," he said in a social media post on Saturday. Jaishankar said he conveyed India's deep appreciation for the efforts of the UAE leadership in ensuring the well-being of the Indian community in the Gulf nation. The minister also expressed confidence that the India-UAE Comprehensive Strategic Partnership will continue to advance further.

VINAY SHUKLA

Moscow

Moscow on Sunday accused Ukraine of violating the Kremlin-declared 32-hour Orthodox Easter truce by targeting positions of Russian troops. Russia recorded nearly two thousand ceasefire violations by Ukrainian forces during the initial 16 hours of the truce, the Russian Defence Ministry said on Sunday. "Although the Easter ceasefire had been declared, the Ukrainian armed forces attacked the positions of Russian troops three times from the Pokrovskoye area last night," it said in a post on the social media platform Max. The settlements of Gai were targeted twice in the

Iranians disappointed but defiant after failure of peace talks

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Tehran

Iranians reacted with a mixture of disappointment and defiance on Sunday after peace talks with the United States failed to reach an agreement following hours-long negotiations. US officials said the talks collapsed over what they described as Iran's refusal to commit to abandoning its nuclear program. Iranian officials blamed the US for failing to reach a deal, without specifying the sticking points. The failure of the high-stakes talks in Pakistan after 21 hours casts doubt over the future of a fragile two-week ceasefire, due to expire on April 22.

Standing outside a newsstand in the capital, Tehran, Farhad Simia told The Associated Press he had hoped for successful negotiations and an end to the fighting, but stood with Iran despite the failure of the talks. "I'm against war. I think negotiation is the better path," Simia, 43, said. He blamed "inappropriate demands" by the US for the failure to reach a deal. Mehdi Hosseini, also 43, agreed: "Considering the advantage Iran seemed to have on the battlefield, there was a real concern that we might lose all those gains in the negotiations. "Whether the talks



succeed or not is one matter, but the fact that the Iranian negotiating team managed to preserve what it achieved

in the war, while refusing to back down and surrender, gives reason for hope." The streets of Tehran were

lined up with large Iranian flags and giant billboards glorifying the country's leaders and military achieve-

Talks ended without deal due to excessive demands made by US: Iranian official

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Islamabad

The talks between Iran and the US in Pakistan have ended without a deal due to "excessive demands" made by the American side, a top Iranian official said on Sunday. Iranian Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmail Baqaei, however, emphasised that "diplomacy never ends." US Vice President JD Vance, who led the American delegation, said the talks failed to reach a peace deal, citing Tehran not forgoing its nuclear programme as one of the key sticking points. He said the American side presented its "final and best offer" to the Iranian side, but it did not accept it. Baqaei, however, said the two sides reached a consensus on some issues, but they held different views regarding "2-3 important matters". "Finally, the talks did not reach an agreement," he was quoted as saying by the state-run Press TV. He said that during the intensive negotiations that began Saturday morning, with Pakistan's mediation, numerous messages and texts were exchanged between the two sides. "In the past 24 hours, discussions were held on various dimensions of the main negotiation topics, including the Strait of Hormuz, the nuclear issue, war reparations, lifting of



Iranian Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmail Baqaei

sanctions, and the complete end to the war against Iran and in the region," Baqaei earlier said in a post on X. "The success of this diplomatic process depends on the seriousness and good faith of the opposing side, refraining from excessive demands and unlawful requests, and the acceptance of Iran's legitimate rights and interests," he added. He said these negotiations were held after 40 days of "imposed war" and in an atmosphere of "mistrust and suspicion".

Sending forces to help with mine-clearing in Strait of Hormuz: US

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Washington

The US military said two of its destroyers transited the critical waterway in the Strait of Hormuz ahead of mine-clearing work, a first since the war began. "We're sweeping the strait. Whether we make a deal or not makes no difference to me," Trump said as talks extended into early Sunday morning. Iran's State media, however, reported the



country's joint military command denied that. Iran's closure of the Strait of Hormuz has proved its biggest strategic advantage in the war. Around a fifth of the world's traded oil had typically passed through on over 100 ships a day. Only 12 have been recorded transiting since the ceasefire. On Saturday, Trump said on social media that the US had begun "clearing out" the strait. "Today, we began the process of establishing a new passage

and we will share this safe pathway with the maritime industry soon," US Central Command commander Adm Brad Cooper later said. The US statement about the destroyers added: "Additional US forces, including underwater drones, will join the clearance effort in the coming days." Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi had said Tehran was entering negotiations with "deep distrust" after strikes on Iran during previous talks.

Russia accuses Ukraine of violating Easter truce

VINAY SHUKLA
Moscow



ceasefire violations on Saturday night, along with Otradnoye in the Dnepropetrovsk Region, it said. All the attacks were repelled, it added. "A total of 1,971 ceasefire violations by the Ukrainian armed forces were recorded between 4:00 pm Moscow time on April 11 and 8:00 am Moscow time on April 12," the Defence Ministry release said on Sunday. Russian forces also thwarted four Ukrainian attempts to advance toward positions near Kondratovka and Novaya Sech in the Sumy Region, as well as Kaleniki in the Donetsk People's Republic, it said. The Ukrainian news portal UNIAN.NET also reported several ceasefire violations

by Russian forces, including an attack on an ambulance in the Sumy region. Russian President Vladimir Putin ordered the Easter truce late Thursday night, directing Defence Minister Andrey Belousov and Chief of General Staff Valery Gerasimov to halt fire starting at 4 pm on Saturday along the 1,300-km front in eastern Ukraine. In a separate development, Putin on Saturday attended the Easter Service in the Cathedral of Christ the Saviour in Moscow. He praised the Russian Orthodox Church and other Christian denominations for their significant role in preserving Russia's historical and cultural heritage, promoting family values, and educating the youth. (PTI)

West Asia conflict diverts US, attention from Asia ahead of Trump's summit with Xi

DIDI TANG Washington

In 2011, President Barack Obama declared it was time for America to leave behind the wars in Iraq and Afghanistan and "pivot" to Asia to counter the rise of China. Fifteen years later, the US finds itself still at war in the Middle East and has pulled military assets from the Asia-Pacific as it aims to eliminate the threat posed by Iran's nuclear and missile programmes. The demands of the Iran war also caused President Donald Trump to delay by several weeks his highly anticipated trip to China, deepening worries that the US is once

again getting distracted at the cost of its strategic interests in Asia, where Beijing seeks to unseat the US as the regional leader. Those skeptical of the US involvement in the Middle East say the war is preventing Trump from adequately preparing for his summit with Chinese leader Xi Jinping next month, when economic interests are on the line, and they warn that a failure to focus on Asia and maintain strong deterrence could lead to greater instability, if China should believe the time is ripe to seize the self-governed island of Taiwan. "This is precisely the wrong time for the United States to

turn away and be sucked into another intractable Middle East conflict," said Danny Russel, a distinguished fellow at the Asia Society Policy Institute. "Rebalancing to Asia is highly relevant to America's national interests, but it has been undercut by many bad decisions." Others defend the president's approach, arguing that the forceful steps he is taking elsewhere, including in Venezuela and Iran, serve to counter China globally. "Beijing is the chief sponsor for the adversaries that President Trump is dealing with sequentially, and it's wise to do this sequentially," Matt Pottinger, who served as



a deputy national security adviser in the first Trump administration, said in a recent podcast. NATO Secretary General Mark Rutte also said conflicts may not be confined to

a single theatre, suggesting that China could call upon its "junior partners" elsewhere to divert US attention if it should move against Taiwan. "Most likely it will not be limited, something in the

Indo-Pacific to the Indo-Pacific," Rutte said, speaking Thursday at the Ronald Reagan Institute in Washington. "It will be a multi-theatre issue." Repercussions in Asia of the Iran war Sen. Jeanne Shaheen, the top Democrat on the Senate Foreign Relations Committee, recently led a bipartisan group of senators to Taiwan, Japan and South Korea, where they heard concerns about the impact of the war on energy costs and about the departure of US military assets, including missile defence systems from South Korea and a rapid-response Marine unit from Japan.

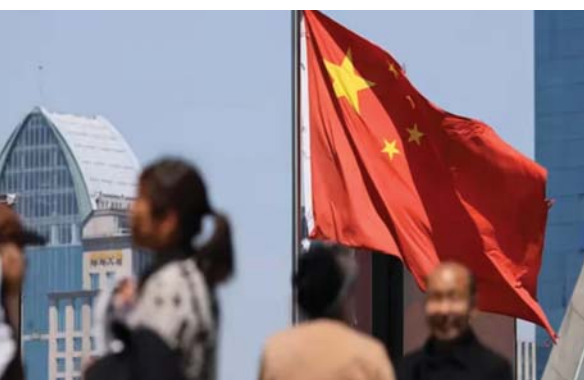
She sought to reassure them of the US commitment to deterring conflicts in Asia and shoring up regional stability. "Failure is not an option," Shaheen told The Associated Press after returning from Asia. "We know China has already said they intend to take Taiwan by force if they need to, and they're on an expedited time schedule. And we also know that what happened in Europe, in the war in Ukraine, in the Middle East is affecting those calculations." Kurt Campbell, who served as deputy secretary of state in the Biden administration, said he's worried that the military capabilities that the US

had patiently accumulated in the Indo-Pacific region might not return in full even after the Iran war ends. The longer the conflict goes on, the more it will pull resources and focus away from Asia, said Zack Cooper, a senior fellow at the American Enterprise Institute who studies the US strategy in Asia. He added that future arms sales to the region also will be negatively affected. "The United States has expended substantial numbers of munitions in the Middle East and will have to keep an increased force presence there, some of which has been redirected from Asia," Cooper said. (AP)

China sets up new county in Xinjiang near Pak-occupied-Kashmir, Afghan border

KJM VARMA
Beijing

China has set up a new county in its volatile Xinjiang province near Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK) and the Afghanistan border in an apparent move to beef up security along the narrow Wakhan Corridor to curb infiltration of Uyghur separatist militants. The county, named Cenling, is located near the Karakoram mountain range and close to the borders with PoK and Afghanistan, underscoring its strategic significance. This is the third new county established by China in Xinjiang, a predominantly Muslim Uyghur region, in just over a year. India last year lodged a protest with China over the creation of Hean and Hekang counties, stating that parts of their jurisdiction fall within



its union territory of Ladakh. Hean includes much of the disputed Aksai Chin plateau, which is part of Ladakh occupied by China in the 1962 war and has remained a focal point of the India-China border dispute. The Xinjiang Uyghur Autonomous Region Government announced the establishment of Cenling on March 26, though details of its administrative divisions

and exact boundaries were not specified. It will be administered by Kashgar prefecture, according to a report in the Hong Kong-based South China Morning Post. Kashgar, a historic city located on the ancient Silk Road, is a strategic gateway connecting China with South and Central Asia. It is also the starting point of the controversial \$60 billion China-Pakistan

Economic Corridor (CPEC), which passes through PoK and has been opposed by India. Experts say the creation of Cenling reflects Beijing's growing focus on border security and governance. Lin Minwang, a professor at the Institute of International Studies in Shanghai-based Fudan University, said the move "reflects China's deeper recognition of the strategic importance of this region." "At a broader level, the decision signals China's emphasis on its borderlands," Lin was quoted as saying by the Post. He noted that the new county is geographically connected to Afghanistan's narrow Wakhan Corridor, a 74-km strip bordering Xinjiang that separates Tajikistan and PoK, highlighting China's security and counterterrorism concerns. (PTI)

Pakistan to receive \$5 billion support from Saudi and Qatar

SAJJAD HUSSAIN
Islamabad

Cash-strapped Pakistan is set to receive \$5 billion in financial support from Saudi Arabia and Qatar, providing a critical buffer for its fragile external position, according to a media report on Sunday.

The expected inflows come at a crucial juncture as Islamabad prepares to repay \$3.5 billion to the United Arab Emirates (UAE) this month and faces pressure on its foreign exchange reserves, the Dawn newspaper said. To avert pressure on Pakistan's weak foreign reserves, Saudi Arabia and Qatar will provide \$5 billion in financial assistance, the report said, quoting sources in the finance ministry. The development coincides with Finance Minister Muhammad Aurangzeb's visit to Washington to attend the IMF-World Bank Spring Meetings and advance Pakistan's economic diplomacy. Aurangzeb will participate in the meetings scheduled from April 13 to 18, where he is expected to hold engagements with senior officials of the International Monetary Fund and the World Bank. Policymakers view these interactions as part of a broader strategic outreach, with indications that traditional factors such as strict



Shehbaz Sharif

programme conditionalities or reliance on third-party guarantors, including the UAE, may carry less weight in the current context. The IMF has stipulated that Pakistan's three key bilateral creditors — Saudi Arabia, China and the UAE — must maintain their cash deposits with the country until the completion of the ongoing three-year programme. It seems the UAE will be replaced by Qatar, the Dawn report said. Ahead of his departure, Aurangzeb met Saudi finance minister Mohammed bin Abdullah Al-Jadaan in Islamabad, who also called on Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif, reflecting continued support at a time when Pakistan has announced plans to clear its UAE debt. Saudi Arabia remains a major source of concessional financing for Pakistan, having rolled over deposits amounting to \$5 billion so far. (PTI)

Tributes pour in for Asha Bhosle in UK

ADITI KHANNA
■ London

Tributes have been pouring in on Sunday for singing legend Asha Bhosle following the news of her passing away in Mumbai, with diaspora groups and artists in the UK honouring her musical legacy.

Describing her as a “sound of Bollywood”, the UK media highlighted the 92-year-old singer’s impact as a cultural icon over the course of a career spanning more than eight decades and made up of thousands of unforgettable tracks. “Bhosle’s distinctive voice breathed life into countless film songs as actors lip-synched to her unforgettable tracks,” reads the BBC’s tribute to Bhosle. “Her pervasive presence in



Bollywood earned her the 1997 hit Cornershop tribute ‘Brimful of Asha’, and she was also known internationally for a collaboration with British musician Boy George. “Her voice had an infectious quality that kept fans on their feet, dancing and

‘Yaadon Ki Baraat’ on the setlist, said it is adding a special tribute segment for the orchestra’s upcoming tour of Bradford, Manchester and Leicester. “The quality of Asha’s songs provides an emotional resonance that changes the environment in the concert hall,” said LBO music director Tim Pottier. “We feel closer to the audience when we perform them. We will do some extra Asha on our forthcoming tour in homage to her extraordinary voice and musicianship,” he said. Bombay Funkadelic, a popular UK-based Bollywood events company, described Asha Bhosle tracks as the “ultimate secret weapon” for their dance floor over the years. “For many in London’s South Asian diaspora, these

nights became more than parties; they were spaces of identity, nostalgia, and reinvention. At their centre was Bhosle’s unmistakable sound,” said founder Jaspreet Bajaj. “There hasn’t been one party amongst the hundreds we have organised over the past two decades where an Asha track wasn’t on the playlist. Even as trends evolved, her presence on the dance floor never faded. She may be gone, but her music and memory will remain on the party scene,” she said. “Her legendary collaborations with RD Burman, especially heavy hitters like ‘Piya Tu Ab to Aaja’ and ‘Dum Maro Dum’, never fail to land and always get the crowd moving,” added DJ Shai Guy. In the UK, Asha Bhosle’s

influence was felt beyond the world of music as the chain Asha’s attracted celebrities and several awards to its fine-dining Indian restaurants in Birmingham and Manchester. “No one can sing or listen to music on an empty stomach,” the singer famously said at the restaurant launch over a decade ago. In 2016, aged 83, she undertook a farewell tour of the UK with performances in London and Birmingham. “They will all remember when they heard a particular song for the last time in concert here,” she said at the time. However, the singer was to return to the UK a few years later for a tribute concert in memory of her musician partner RD Burman as a final bow. (PTI)

Nepal pays tributes to legendary singer

SHIRISH B PRADHAN
■ Kathmandu

Nepal on Sunday paid tribute to the popular Bollywood singer Asha Bhosle, who passed away in Mumbai after suffering a heart attack. Bhosle was 92, and she had contributed several songs for Nepalese films during the 1970s and 1980s, which made her popular among the Nepalese audience. “She has given her voice to the Nepalese films and songs, which helped Nepalese music to get connected to the global taste,” writes onlinekhabar.com, a popular online news portal. “Her contribution to Nepalese music helped Nepalese playback songs gain



height. Her songs not only become a hit, but they are also deeply connected to the Nepalese sentiment,” added onlinekhabar.com. Asha has worked with Nepal’s noted music personalities such as Narayan Gopal, Sambhujit Baskota, Kiran Kharel, and Udit Narayan, among others. Some of Asha’s Nepali hit songs include ‘Gairi Khet ma,’ ‘Mohani Lagla Hai,’ and ‘Mirmire Sanjha ma.’ (PTI)

Campaign against Iran not over, existential threats removed: Israeli PM Netanyahu

HARINDER MISHRA
■ Jerusalem

Claiming “historic achievements” in the fight against Iran, Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said in a video statement on Saturday that the “campaign is not yet over,” but Israel managed to foil Iran’s nuclear ambitions.

“The campaign against Iran is not over, we still have more to do. But even now it can be clearly stated that we have historic achievements,” Netanyahu said in the video in Hebrew.

“We went into the campaign because Iran was very close to nuclear weapons and the capability to produce hundreds of missiles per day. Two existential threats that we had to remove from over our heads,” the Israeli Prime Minister asserted.

“Khamenei wanted to conceal the production of missiles and the nuclear programme deep underground in such a way that even B-2 aircraft wouldn’t have been able to reach it. We could not stand idly by,” he claimed.

Amid questions about the fate of more than 400 Kilograms of enriched uranium still lying in Iran, the Israeli leader reiterated that it will be removed from the Islamic Republic through diplomatic process or by use of force. Moving to a map of the



West Asia with the Iranian axis highlighted in red soon after the start of his video statement, Netanyahu said, “they wanted to strangle us, and we are strangling them.” “We hit them, we still have more to do,” he stressed. The statement came while US and Iranian negotiators are meeting in Islamabad to discuss a potential ceasefire.

The Israeli leader repeated that he spent much of his life ensuring that Iran won’t achieve nuclear weapons, including by approving covert operations to delay it and also informing the world of the danger. “But the world wouldn’t hear,” he said adding, Israel “broke the barrier of fear” by striking Iran last June. Applauding the support received from Israeli citizens, Netanyahu said that Iran has been weakened and is “begging for a ceasefire”. “This is reflected in internal conflicts at the top,

we know about this. We see the growing difficulty (in Iran) in meeting the needs of citizens. This is reflected in the profound weakening of the terror regime. Iran is no longer the same Iran”, he claimed stressing that Israel has emerged stronger in the process. “Those who threatened to destroy us are now fighting for their own survival,” the Israeli Premier asserted.

He also claimed major achievemnets on other fronts that posed threat to Israel — Syria, Houthis in Yemen, Hezbollah in Lebanon and Hamas in Gaza. “As a result of the strength we showed, Lebanon reached out several times in the past month to begin direct peace talks. I approved this subject to two conditions: we want to achieve the disarmament of Hezbollah and we want a real peace agreement that will last for generations,” Netanyahu said. (PTI)

Polls open in Hungary in key election that could unseat populist PM Orban

JUSTIN SPIKE/SAM MCNEIL
■ Budapest (Hungary)

Hungarians were casting ballots Sunday in what is widely seen as Europe’s most consequential election this year, a vote that could unseat populist Prime Minister Viktor Orban, an ally of US President Donald Trump, after 16 years in power.

It’s a key moment for Orban, the European Union’s longest-serving leader and one of its biggest antagonists, who has travelled a long road from his early days as a liberal, anti-Soviet fire-brand to the Russia-friendly nationalist admired today by the global far-right. Polls opened at 6 am local

time and were scheduled to close at 7 pm Orban and his top challenger, Peter Magyar, arrived at separate polling stations in Budapest at nearly the same time to cast their votes.

Speaking to reporters outside, Orban, 62, said the campaign had been “a great national moment on our side” and thanked activists and supporters for their work. “I’m here to win,” he said. The election was being closely watched in countries around Europe and beyond, which is a testament to the outsized role Orban occupies in far-right populist politics worldwide. Members of Trump’s “Make America Great Again” move-



ment are among those who see Orban’s Government and his Fidesz political party as shining examples of conservative, anti-globalist politics in action, while he is reviled by advocates of liberal

democracy and the rule of law. After casting his vote, Magyar told reporters that the election was “a choice between East or West, propaganda or honest public dis-

India’s growth a huge global opportunity: Kwatra

YOSHITA SINGH
■ New York

India’s economic growth journey is a huge opportunity for its international partners, the country’s envoy in Washington Ambassador Vinay Mohan Kwatra said, underlining that the US is “front and centre” and among New Delhi’s most consequential partnerships.

Kwatra made the remarks during a special address on Saturday at the Columbia Indian Economy Summit 2026: ‘The Quest for a Developed India’, hosted at Columbia University by the Deepak and Neera Raj Centre on Indian Economic Policies



at the School of International and Public Affairs (SIPA). “India’s economic growth, our own journey, is not just for our own first principles of economic growth and prosperity, but it’s also a huge opportunity for our international partners. The United States is

said the India-US partnership is “among the most important and most consequential” in advancing shared priorities and navigating evolving global shifts.

He expressed confidence that India will continue to drive economic growth and prosperity for its people while achieving the vision of ‘Viksit Bharat’ by 2047.

“We in India are in a transformative phase of our journey, of our economic growth, the evolution of our society... At the same time, we also live in a uniquely instructive phase of global shifts,” the envoy said, reiterating that India remains confident in its priorities and firmly focused

on attaining developed nation status by 2047.

Underscoring the “salience and substance” of strong international partnerships, Kwatra said the India-US partnership spans Government-to-Government, Government-to-business, business-to-business and people-to-people ties. “In terms of sectoral spread within these four buckets, one key segment for us is strategic political and security,” he said, noting efforts to reimagine challenges and opportunities through initiatives such as the Quad, the India-Middle East Economic Corridor, and the broader global strategic partnership with the US. (PTI)

Pak’s first container vessel reaches Karachi port after reopening of Strait of Hormuz

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Karachi

MV Selen has become Pakistan’s first container vessel to reach Karachi Port after the Strait of Hormuz was reopened in the wake of the ceasefire between the US and Iran.

The vessel MV Selen, arriving from Jebel Ali in the UAE, docked at the Karachi Port on Saturday night, the Karachi Port Trust (KPT) said.

The arrival of MV SELEN, operated by NLC (AP Line) signalled the resumption of containerised trade and reinforced confidence in maritime supply chains, the KPT said in a statement.

Weeks after the conflict started in West Asia, Iran and the US on April 8 agreed on a conditional ceasefire that included the opening of the Strait of Hormuz, the strategically located key waterway between the Persian Gulf and the Gulf of Oman handling roughly 20 per cent of global energy supply.



The strategic waterway was one of the 10 main points — Iran wants to control the Strait of Hormuz — on the agenda in Islamabad for the first direct US-Iranian talks that took place over the weekend. The failure to reach an agreement has raised doubts about the effectiveness of the fragile two-week ceasefire, as well as the prospect of reopening the Strait of Hormuz to stabilise the global energy market.

Police remove fuel protesters from Dublin centre as disruption over soaring costs continues

BRIAN MELLEYS
■ London

Police broke up a blockade in the centre of Dublin by fuel protesters who have brought much of Ireland to a standstill during the past week.

The protests came, as the Government on Sunday prepared to approve cost-cutting measures they hope will end the six days of disruption over soaring costs at the pump.

As tractors and trucks that had blocked O’Connell Street were rolling out of the capital, protests continued elsewhere, with police on the other side of the country clashing with demonstrators at the Galway docks where a military vehicle was used to knock down a makeshift barrier.

The protests have caused chaos as blockades at Ireland’s only oil refinery and several vital depots prevented



tanker trucks from delivering fuel to service stations and more than a third of pumps ran dry. Slow-moving convoys of vehicles also caused traffic jams on major highways.

Police began cracking down Saturday, using pepper spray to help clear protesters at the Whitegate refinery in County Cork and vowing to remove others who were endangering

critical infrastructure and public safety because gas shortages could prevent response by emergency services.

“They are not a legitimate form of protest,” Irish police Commissioner Justin Kelly said on Saturday. “We gave the blockers fair warning that we were moving to enforcement and they choose to ignore it and continue to hold the country to ransom.”

But a farmer who has become a spokesman for the group in Dublin said he was angry their peaceful protest had been “ambushed” by an army of officers overnight.

Christopher Duffy said police threatened to tow their heavy vehicles, so they had to leave.

“These vehicles are very expensive with automatic transmissions and everything, and if they drag them with the engine not on they could wreck them,” Duffy said. (AP)

First-ever life-size Swami Vivekananda statue unveiled in US

YOSHITA SINGH
■ New York

The first-ever life-size statue of Swami Vivekananda in the US was unveiled in Seattle, honouring the renowned Indian philosopher and spiritual leader.

The life-size bronze statue, installed at the busy Westlake Square in downtown Seattle, is the first such installation hosted by a city Government anywhere in the US, officials said.

Sculpted by Indian artist Naresh Kumar Kumawat, it was jointly unveiled on Saturday by Seattle Mayor Katie Wilson and Consul General of India in Seattle Prakash Gupta.

“From Chicago 1893 to Seattle 2026 Seattle’s skyline has a new Indian icon: Swami Vivekananda!



Swami Vivekananda Monument is unveiled by Consul General of India in Seattle Prakash Gupta, and others, at Westlake Square in Seattle, United States

City of Seattle becomes the first city Government to host the Swami Vivekananda Monument in the heart of downtown Seattle,” the Consulate General of India in Seattle said in a social media post.

Addressing the event, Wilson said the monument reflects Seattle’s inclusive spirit and strengthens cultural ties between India and the diverse metropolitan tech hub in the US Pacific Northwest. The statue has been gifted by the Indian Council of Cultural Relations (ICCR) to the City of Seattle in recognition of its “in recognition of the city’s rich multicultural character and spirit of inclusivity”, the Indian mission in Seattle said in a statement.

The unveiling of the statue was held on the occasion of the celebration of ICCR Day and is part of India’s broader cultural diplomacy initia-

tives aimed at strengthening people-to-people ties between India and the US Pacific Northwest, the Consulate said.

Located at the bustling Westlake Square, which sees over 400,000 visitors daily, the monument stands near prominent landmarks including the Amazon headquarters ‘Spheres’, the Seattle Convention Centre and the Seattle Centre Monorail.

The unveiling ceremony was attended by several local leaders, including mayors from cities in the Greater Seattle area, community representatives and members of the Indian-American diaspora. Swami Vivekananda had delivered his historic address at the World’s Parliament of Religions in Chicago in 1893, introducing Hindu philosophy to a global audience. (PTI)

12 more Indian fishermen held by Sri Lankan Navy



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Colombo

At least 12 more Indian fishermen have been arrested and their trawler confiscated by the Sri Lankan Navy for alleged poaching in Sri Lankan waters.

“During an operation conducted in the dark hours of April 11, the Sri Lanka Navy seized one Indian fishing boat and apprehended 12 Indian fishermen while they were poaching in Sri Lankan waters off Kovilam in Karainagar Jaffna,” an official statement said.

On April 8, at least 10 Indian fishermen were arrested and their trawler confiscated by the Sri Lankan Navy for alleged poaching in Sri Lankan waters in the sea area North of Mannar on Wednesday. So far, this year the Sri Lankan Navy has seized 16 trawlers and arrested 112 Indian fishermen for alleged poaching.

The fishermen issue is a contentious one in the ties between India and Sri Lanka, with Lankan Navy personnel even firing at Indian fishermen in the Palk Strait and seizing their boats in several alleged incidents of illegally entering Sri Lankan territorial waters.

PROSPECT



Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma at Khatu Shyam Baba temple near Sikar in Rajasthan



G P Singh, DG CRPF delivering Convocation Address at IIM Rohtak

NCLAT reaffirms project-wise insolvency against realty firms

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The National Company Law Appellate Tribunal has reaffirmed that insolvency proceedings initiated by homebuyers against realty firms must remain confined to the specific project where default has occurred and cannot extend to other projects of the corporate debtor.

The appellate tribunal highlighted that putting all other projects of the realty firms, which are unrelated to the default, is not in the interest of homebuyers and other stakeholders of other projects.

"The law is well settled that when financial creditors, homebuyers who belong to one project and who file a Section 7 application on account of default committed by the corporate debtor with respect to the project, the CIRP has to confine to the said projects," said the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT).

A two-member NCLAT bench, while deciding an appeal by Navin M Raheja, said jeopardising unrelated projects would not serve the interests of homebuyers and stakeholders elsewhere, making clear that the corporate insolvency resolution process (CIRP) is to be ring-



fenced project-wise.

NCLAT, which last month passed an order related to another project of Raheja Developers and held that the CIRP is confined to only one project, Raheja Shilas, said that the judgment is fully applicable in the facts of the present case and has to be followed.

Applying the same, the NCLAT had confined the ongoing CIRP of Raheja Developers to "Krishna Housing Scheme" only, and not against the entire group.

Passing a final order, the appellate tribunal also held that in the project-wise insolvency proceedings against the realty firm, claims also filed by the creditors and

stakeholders should be confined to that specific project.

"When the CIRP is initiated project-wise, it is but natural that the claims filed by the stakeholders have to be confined to the project against which the CIRP is proceeding," said the NCLAT bench, comprising Chairperson Justice Ashok Bhushan and Member (Technical) Barun Mitra.

The insolvency appellate tribunal also directed the resolution professional "to issue a corrigendum" to the publication issued in 'Form-A' asking the stakeholders pertaining to "Krishna Housing Scheme" to submit the claim within 14 days as per CIRP Regulations, 2016.

"We, however, are of the view that in view of this appeal being decided today and CIRP being confined to the Project "Krishna Housing Scheme", the IRP is required to issue reference in pursuance of his earlier publication, requiring the claims to be confined to Project "Krishna Housing Scheme," the tribunal said in its 30-page-long order.

Navin M Raheja has challenged an earlier order passed by the New Delhi Bench of the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT), which had, on August 21, 2025, admitted a Section 7 application filed by several flat buyers of Project Raheja Krishna Housing Scheme.

Krishna Housing Scheme was developed under the Affordable Housing framework, qualifying for Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana and Rinn Yojana benefits. It comprises 11 towers, with 1-2 BHK configurations and offers a total of 1,644 residential units, along with commercial spaces.

Raheja had pleaded that constructions were adversely impacted by the COVID-19 pandemic. The cost of the residential project increased from ₹183.36 crore to ₹204 crore. It had defaulted in completing the construction and delivering possession within the stipulated period.

Coal India absorbs cost surge to shield consumers from price spike

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

State-owned Coal India Limited is absorbing rising input costs to protect consumers from higher coal prices, even as expenses for key inputs, such as explosives and industrial diesel, have surged sharply following the West Asia conflict.

The company said it has chosen not to pass on the increase, warning that doing so could trigger a cascading impact across sectors reliant on coal.

It is also compensating

affordable, including lowering reserve prices in select e-auctions, increasing auction frequency and offering higher volumes to the market.

The measures are aimed at cushioning downstream industries and consumers from escalating energy costs, as the company seeks to maintain stable coal prices amid broader volatility in fuel markets.

Officials said any pass-through of the mounting prices would lead to a cascading effect.

The company is also compensating for the increased



contractors operating in its mines for higher diesel costs.

Prices of ammonium nitrate - a key component accounting for about 60 per cent of explosives used in opencast mining - have risen 44 per cent to ₹72,750 per tonne as of April 1 from pre-war levels. This has pushed up the average cost of explosives by around 26 per cent to nearly Rs 49,800 per tonne by end-March.

Coal India's subsidiaries consume about 0.9 million tonnes of explosives annually. This entire cost is being absorbed by Coal India, the company said.

Diesel prices have also surged, rising roughly 54 per cent to ₹142 per litre from around ₹92 in mid-March. The company consumed about 4,19,000 kilolitres of diesel in the fiscal year ended March 2026.

Despite the cost pressures, Coal India has taken steps to keep supplies

price of the industrial diesel to the contractors operating in CIL's mines, who purchase it in bulk quantities.

Prior to the West Asian crisis, ammonia nitrate (AN) prices applicable to Coal India Ltd (CIL) held steady from August 2025 till January 2026 before touching ₹50,500 per metric tonne as of March 1, 2026, and since then have taken an upward route.

This sharp increase in the price of AN had a direct bearing on the cost of explosives that CIL uses in large quantities in blasting operations to uncover overburden and expose coal seams. As a result, the average cost of explosives shot up by around 26 per cent from ₹39,588 per metric tonne in February 2026 to ₹49,783 per metric tonne by March end, it said.

In the just-ended 2025-26 fiscal, the consumption of diesel was around 4.19 lakh kilolitres (KL). One KL is equivalent to 1,000 litres.

48th foundation day of Mahamana Malviya Mission celebrated

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The 48th foundation day of Mahamana Malviya Mission was celebrated at Malviya Smriti Bhawan, DDU marg, New Delhi on Saturday under vibrant leadership of Hari Shankar Singh (National President of MMM) & Dr VP Singh (Secretary General of MMM).

On 9th April, 1978, Mahamana Malviya Mission was created by BHU alumnus on the direction of Bhau Rao Devras (then deputy of RSS)

and Ashok Singhal (Chief of Vishwa Hindu Parishad), just to propagate the ideas and culture of Bharat Ratna Mahamana Madan Mohan Malviya ji to next generation of India.

Nithishwer Kumar (Addition Secretary, Ministry of Women and Child development, Govt. of India) was the Chief Guest of the function and he talked about various dimension in the personality of Bharat Ratna Malviya including his contributions in freedom movement of India. In the presidential speech,



Hari Shankar Singh, told the audience about the history of creation of Mahamana Malviya Mission and Dr V P Singh too addressed the august audience and told that how the the Mahamana Malviya was able to help the freedom fighters of Chouri Chopra Kand as an advocate, particularly when none of the advocate was ready to fight this case.

Further, he also talked about the role Malviya Pune Pact. A welcome speech was delivered by Animesh Saxena (President of Delhi branch of

MMM) and Anchoring was Archana Gupta. The vote of thanks was given by Dr. CB Tripathi, former president of Indraprastha branch of MMM. In his deliberation, Dr Tripathi proposed to constitute a committee of senior members of MMM for the creation vision documents and roadmap of MMM for next 10 year. Govind Ram, a senior member and chief editor of MMM quarterly magazine was also addressed the audience and magazine was unfolded by dignitaries on Dais during the function.

DAILY SUDOKU

9		1				8	
				2	4		
3		5			7	1	6
	5			4			8
7	8		2		9		3
1				8		5	
5	7	2				8	1
		1	8				
	3			4			7

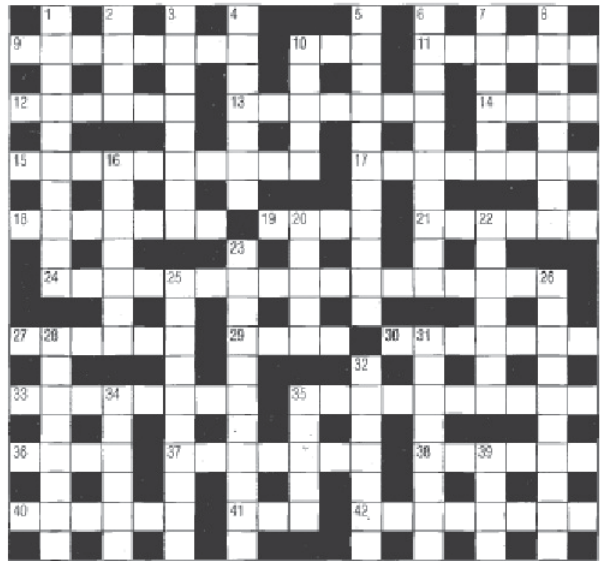
HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction-no maths involved.



SOLUTION (11.04.26)								
7	8	3	5	2	9	1	4	6
6	5	9	4	3	1	2	8	7
1	2	4	7	6	8	9	5	3
4	9	1	6	8	5	7	3	2
8	3	2	1	7	4	6	9	5
5	7	6	3	9	2	8	1	4
3	4	7	8	1	6	5	2	9
9	6	8	2	5	3	4	7	1
2	1	5	9	4	7	3	6	8

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
MONDAY | APRIL 13, 2026



ACROSS

9 One went into show business many, many years ago (5,3)

10 Overheard the figure (3)

11 Show it's duck meat (6)

12 Try to get sun and plenty of it (6)

13 Give one a posting to headquarters (7)

14 For wood, it's a bargain! (4)

15 Enquired into, when one left the hotel (7,3)

17 Does it have a lot to learn about being a pest? (8)

18 Gives one the job of getting the particulars? (7)

19 She's a c-cat! (4)

21 The jacket with the label going to a Dr Turner (6)

24 Seizing the opportunity for imposing on (7)

DOWN

1 The fondness you have for someone you're stuck on? (10)

2 A cheap cut? (4)

3 The last thing said is "We're tumbling in an avalanche" (8)

4 Writes back first from a boarding house (7)

5 Calling on, for the next bout (6,5)

6 Do patients, mending, love one being brought in by visitors? (10)

7 Asked to make an offer for the home (6)

8 A shopkeeper with whom no secret is safe? (8)

10 Land upright and turn (5)

16 A "22" and a really good one (7)

one's good nature (6,9,2)

27 If you say it's pretty, will it snap back "Phooey"? (6)

29 Get cheques in the post? (4)

30 Wonderful workers in a bottling factory? (7)

33 Sticking together, which is understandable (8)

35 What you were baking when the oven fused? (10)

36 Prompt the star (4)

37 Made out the sow had been let loose in the fields (7)

38 Saves from the mobs, it is stated (6)

40 Trees not found in the mountains, we're told (6)

41 You know him (3)

42 Says it isn't on, anyhow, to me (8)

20 Brought back, for the clergyman, one pound of meat (5)

22 Somebody snapping the rough sea? (7)

23 Leaves tyre marks behind as one heads towards? (5,6)

25 The bottom ones earn her the greatest income (10)

26 Sending on to be used as a shield? (10)

28 The highest of the high, in particular (5,3)

31 Had done better than the other stars? (8)

32 Tot taking an ice-cream out to eat (7)

34 Am first changing the finale (6)

35 Canoodle in the wood (5)

39 To help, brought round a cold tart (4)

India boosts 5-kg LPG supply, accelerates PNG rollout amid West Asia disruption

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India has ramped up supply of smaller 5-kg LPG cylinders and accelerated the rollout of piped natural gas (PNG) connections as it manages fuel availability amid disruptions triggered by the West Asia conflict.

More than 13 lakh 5-kg free trade LPG cylinders have been sold since March 23, with daily sales rising above 100,000 units, as authorities expand access for migrant workers and low-income consumers, according to an official statement.

At the same time, over 424,000 new PNG connections have been activated since March, with more than 30,000 consumers surrendering LPG connections as part of the transition.



The six-week long war in West Asia has disrupted global energy supply. India relied on import of half of its crude oil, 40 per cent of its gas and 85-90 per cent of LPG from the region was also impacted.

While it has managed to make up for the shortfall in crude oil by sourcing from other regions, LPG supplies have been impacted.

The Government has priori-

tised LPG supply to domestic households at the cost of cuts in supplies to commercial users like hotels and restaurants. To make up for the shortfall for those who do not have subsidised cooking gas LPG connections, it has ramped up supply of market priced 5 kg cylinders.

As against sale of about 77,000 5 kg cylinders in pre-crisis February, daily sales have topped over 1 lakh in the last two-three weeks.

The statement said domestic LPG supplies remain stable overall, with no reported stock-outs and over 52 lakh cylinders delivered on April 11.

Online bookings account for about 98 per cent of demand, while delivery authentication systems now cover 93 per cent of transactions to curb diversion.

Army launches Sikkim's first Border Village Community Radio

TONY DAS
■ Gangtok

The Indian Army has established 88.4 FM Radio Sikkim Sundari, Sikkim's first Border Village Community Radio Station in East Sikkim, to improve communication and information access in remote high-altitude border areas.

Dedicated to the citizens of India in Sikkim, the station addresses challenges of geographic isolation, harsh weather, and limited mobile and internet connectivity. It aims to bridge the information gap by providing reliable and timely communication.

The radio station will broadcast local news, weather updates, and information on Government schemes, while also promoting regional culture and addressing community issues. It will provide an opportunity for local youth



to participate, develop communication skills, and contribute to community engagement.

The station was inaugurated in the presence of senior officers of Trishakti Corps, representatives of the civil administration, and members of the local community.

The station will host programmes on agriculture, education, and community development.

A senior military official stated that the initiative will help connect communities, amplify local voices, and support development in remote areas.

BRIEFLY

Fury dominates Makhmudov in latest comeback



Tyson Fury showed little rust in dominating Arslanbek Makhmudov for a unanimous decision victory and immediately challenged a ringside Anthony Joshua to fight him next. "Let's give the fight fans what they want," Fury bellowed after going 12 rounds in his latest comeback. A long-awaited Fury-Joshua heavyweight showdown would be one of the biggest fights in British boxing history. Joshua sat ringside and appeared to be using his phone to film portions of the fight at Tottenham Hotspur Stadium. He didn't commit to anything when Fury (35-2-1) yelled into the Netflix microphone: "Do you accept my challenge?" Joshua said, "I'll punch you up," and "I'm the landlord. You work for me." As for Saturday's fight, the self-described "Gypsy King" had a fairly slow start but otherwise dictated the pace with his left jab and in later rounds landed frequent lead uppercuts on Makhmudov (21-3). Two judges scored it 120-108 and the other 119-109. The 36-year-old Joshua, a former world champion, later told Netflix in an interview: "Contracts will be sent over."

Unwell captain Salima to miss Argentina tour



Star goalkeeper and former captain Savita Punia will return to the national women's hockey team after 10 months but indisposed skipper Salima Tete will be missing from action when India take on Argentina in the first game of the four-match series, here on Monday. Savita has not competed since June 2025 as she took a break from the game due to personal reasons. Salima, a quality mid-fielder, is still recovering from a bout of chicken pox. The tour will serve as the ideal preparation for India ahead of FIH Nations Cup, FIH Hockey World Cup Belgium & Netherlands 2026, and the Asian Games later this year. Ahead of the tour, the Indian women's team trained in Bengaluru before departing for Argentina on Thursday evening. Having finished runners-up at World Cup Qualifiers 2026 held in Hyderabad, the team will be looking to carry that momentum forward into the tour and the rest of the year. Experienced forward Navneet Kaur will serve as the captain of the team during the tour in the absence of Salima. Navneet had recently won the Hockey India Balbir Singh Sr Award for Player of the Year for her consistent performance. The return of veteran India goalkeeper Savita Punia will be a huge boost, with Bichu Devi Kharibam expected to share goalkeeping duties with her.

Yamal stars in Barcelona 4-1 win over Espanyol

JOSEPH WILSON
■ Barcelona

Lamine Yamal secured Barcelona's 4-1 win over Espanyol after setting up Ferran Torres for a double and the La Liga leaders took another step toward retaining the title.

Yamal passed for Ferran to score in the 10th and 25th minutes before the teenage phenom ensured the victory in the 87th with Espanyol threatening to equalise. Marcus Rashford made it four for the hosts at Camp Nou in the 89th. Barcelona capitalised on Real Madrid's 1-1 draw at home to Girona on Friday to increase its lead to nine points with seven rounds remaining. Barcelona and Madrid will try to over-



come losses in the Champions League quarterfinals in their next games after Barcelona lost to Atletico Madrid 2-0 and Madrid fell to Bayern Munich 2-1 this week. While Madrid will travel to Germany on a three-game winless streak, Barcelona's

Vaishali outplays Goryachkina to extend lead

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Paphos (Cyprus)

Indian Grandmaster R Vaishali continued her remarkable run and defeated Aleksandra Goryachkina of Russia in the 11th round of the Women's Candidates tournament here on Saturday. With her fourth victory in the event, Vaishali took her tally to an impressive seven points from 11 games. For Russian Goryachkina, the loss virtually ended her chances in the event as she remained on five points, two adrift of the tournament leader. Vaishali's victory also ensured that she stretched her lead by a full point over nearest rivals Anna Muzychuk of Ukraine and Jiner Zhu of



China who were both held to draws by Kateryna Lagno of Russia and Divya Deshmukh respectively. Playing white, Goryachkina surprisingly employed the London system in this key game and Vaishali played nonchalantly in the opening to get close to an equal position in the early middle game. The Russian wanted to complicate matters after an early exchange of Queens but

Vaishali proved she was far ahead in the calculation on this day as she matched Goryachkina move for move and pounced on a creative idea that entailed trapping of white's rook right in the middle of the board. Vaishali lost just one pawn and a minor piece in the bargain and in the resulting position her technique was immaculate to romp home. It may be recalled that Vaishali started off very slowly in the event drawing the first four games followed by a loss against Jiner Zhu of China but since the sixth round has scored as many as four wins and two draws which also means she is peaking at the right time. In the open section,

Vaishali's younger brother R Praggnanandhaa continued to struggle as he missed out on a simple tactic to score a victory over Matthias Bluebaum of Germany. Hikaru Nakamura of United States played out a draw with Wei Yi of China with both conceding that they were out of the race while Dutchman Anish Giri also played out a draw with Andrey Esipenko of Russia. Tournament leader by almost a mile, Javokhir Sindarov of Uzbekistan fought hard to get a draw with pre-tournament favourite Fabiano Caruana of United States to take his tally to a nearly unassailable 8.5 points. For the chess pundits, the

tournament is almost over as Javokhir enjoys a two point lead over Giri with just three rounds to come. **Results round 11:** R Praggnanandhaa (Ind, 4.5) drew with Matthias Bluebaum (5); Anish Giri Ned (6.5) drew with Andrey Esipenko (Rus, 4); Fabiano Caruana (Usa, 5.5) drew with Javokhir Sindarov (Uzb, 8.5); Hikaru Nakamura (Usa, 5) drew with Wei Yi (Chn, 5). **Women:** Aleksandra Goryachkina (Rus, 5) lost to R Vaishali (Ind, 7); Kateryna Lagno (Rus, 5.5) drew with Anna Muzychuk (Ukr); Zhongyi Tan (Chn, 4) drew with playing Bibisara Assuabayeva (Kaz, 5.5); Jiner Zhu (Chn, 6) drew with Divya Deshmukh (Ind, 5).

Marie-Louise Eta named Bundesliga coach

CIARAN FAHEYAP
■ Berlin

Union Berlin has appointed Marie-Louise Eta as the first female coach in charge of a men's team in the Bundesliga as it bids to ensure its league survival. The 34-year-old Eta takes over from Steffen Baumgart, who was fired with his assistants Danilo de Souza and Kevin McKenna after the team's 3-1 loss at last-place Heidenheim on Saturday. Union announced just before midnight. Eta, who was coaching the Under-19 men's team and agreed earlier this month to take over as coach of Union's women's team



next season, has five games to secure Union's Bundesliga survival. She made history in 2023 as the first female assistant coach in the Bundesliga and across the top divisions of Europe's "big five" soccer leagues. She had to step in

for media duties for head coach Nenad Bjelica when he was suspended for three games in 2024. "I'm delighted that Marie Louise Eta has agreed to take on this role on an interim basis before she becomes head coach of the women's first team as planned in the summer," Union sporting director Horst Heldt said in a statement. Baumgart, a former Union player, was appointed during the 2024-25 winter break but Heldt said recent results prompted the club to take drastic action. "We've had an completely disappointing second half of the season so far and we're not letting the table fool us — our situation remains precarious and we desperately need points to secure our place in the league." Defeat in Heidenheim left Union in 11th place in the 18-team division, just seven points clear of St. Pauli in the relegation zone with five rounds remaining. "Two wins out of 14 games since the winter break and the performances shown in recent weeks do not give us the confidence that we can turn things around with the current setup. We have therefore decided to make a fresh start," Heldt said. Union next hosts Wolfsburg, which is also fighting for survival, next weekend. (AP)

Rory McIlroy stumbles at Masters, shares lead

DOUG FERGUSONAP
■ Augusta

That one-man show at the Masters gave way to a wide-open chase for the green jacket with a stunning turn of events that forced Rory McIlroy to remind himself where he was at the end of Saturday instead of where he started. The six-shot lead was gone in 11 holes. Instead of only two players within six shots of him, there were nine players within six shots of McIlroy and co-leader Cameron Young by the of the day. "There's a lot of guys in with a chance tomorrow. I'm still tied for the best score going into tomorrow, so I can't forget that," McIlroy said. "But I do know I'm going to have to be better if

I want to have a chance to win." It felt like the coronation had started when McIlroy put himself in the Masters record book with the largest 36-hole lead in history, even though the defending champion had cautioned, "I know what can happen around here, good and bad." The good belonged to Young, that mixture of power and calm carrying him to a 7-under 65, and to Scottie Scheffler, the world's No. 1 player and two-time Masters champion.

McIlroy was in the trees, in the water, in all sorts of places he would rather not be, including sharing space atop the leaderboard. He finished with a 73, surprising only because it was the



lowest scoring average (70.63) ever for a third round at Augusta National. "Didn't quite have it today," McIlroy said before going off to the range to figure out what went wrong. He is last in the field in driving accuracy among the 54 players who made the cut. Young set his own Masters record, the first player to have at least a share of the 54-hole lead

when starting eight shots behind. But he was steady and brilliant, chipping in for birdie on the par-3 fourth, converting a huge break when his tee shot on the par-5 13th crashed out of the tree and into the fairway, even salvaging a bogey with a bold wedge from the same spot where he had just come up short and into the water on the par-5 15th. He briefly took the lead with a 20-foot birdie on the 16th.

"You just are constantly aware of the fact that this place can bite you," Young said. "So to me, it's just a really, really clear mandate that an easy par is never bad. And if you're playing that well, you're going to back your way into some birdies at some point." (AP)

Nantes closer to Ligue 1 relegation

JEROME PUGMIREAP
■ Paris

Nantes slid closer to relegation after drawing at fellow struggler Auxerre 0-0 in Ligue 1. Nantes was in 17th place and five points behind Auxerre in 16th, which is the promotion-relegation playoff spot.

Eight-time champion Nantes was one of France's most storied sides but has narrowly avoided relegation in recent seasons. Although Nantes has played one game less than Auxerre its game in hand is at leader Paris Saint-Germain. In Saturday's other game, Rennes maintained its push for a Champions League place with a 2-1 home win over



Angers. Victory moved Rennes up to fifth place, with the top three earning an automatic spot in the Champions League and the side in fourth spot entering qualifying. An own goal gave Rennes an early lead

and Jordan forward Mousa Al-Tamari latched onto a long ball to lob the goalkeeper in the 25th minute. Angers pulled a goal back midway into the second half through 18-year-old forward Peter Prosper.(AP)

AC Milan booted off after shock home loss to Udinese

DANIELLA MATAR
■ Milan

After falling out of the Serie A title race, AC Milan is looking nervously at the teams behind it following a shock 3-0 loss at home to Udinese.

The Rossoneri were not only nine points below league leader Inter Milan but just three points above fourth-placed Juventus, which won at Atalanta 1-0. Fifth-placed Como was two points further back and hosts Inter Milan on Sunday. AC Milan was loudly jeered off the field after its third defeat in four matches. "It's part of the game: When you win you're good,



when you lose you're not. Tonight the whistles are right, even if the team worked hard," Milan coach Massimiliano Allegri said. "Now we have to look at the (next) match, and this defeat

must represent the opportunity to do better in the next one. "The team must react. ãi. This defeat must make us understand that the Champions League place is at risk." Nicolò Zaniolo starred for Udinese at San Siro. He counterattacked from deep inside his own half and rode a couple of challenges before spreading it to the right for Arthur Atta, whose cross was deflected in by Davide Baresaghi — going down as an own goal by the young Milan defender. Zaniolo also set up Udinese's second in the 37th minute with a sensational cross from the right for Jürgen Ekkelenkamp's header. (AP)

Bayern smashes Bundesliga's goal record

CIARAN FAHEYAP
■ Berlin

Bayern Munich warmed up for Real Madrid's visit by smashing the Bundesliga record for goals in a season and taking a major step toward yet another league title.

Leon Goretzka scored Bayern's record-breaking 102nd league goal of the season as relegation-threatened St. Pauli was routed 5-0 away. Bayern opened a 12-point gap over Borussia Dortmund with five rounds remaining. Jamal Musiala equaled the record of 101 goals set by Bayern's 1971-72 team featuring Franz Beckenbauer and Gerd Müller by opening the scoring with a header in the



ninth minute, and Goretzka broke the record with a volley in the 53rd. Michael Olise took the tally to 103 just a minute later, Nicolas Jackson grabbed Bayern's fourth, and Raphael Guerreiro scored late to lift the mark to 105. The home fans' biggest cheer came

when Goretzka had another goal ruled out after a VAR check for offside before referee Tobias Stieler blew the final whistle.

Bayern coach Vincent Kompany fielded a weakened side as he rested a host of players including top scorer Harry Kane and

Aleksandar Pavlovic for Wednesday's match against Madrid in the Champions League quarterfinals. Bayern is defending a 2-1 advantage from the first leg in Madrid on Tuesday.

Dortmund derailed, Schlotterbeck booed: Bayer Leverkusen defeated second-placed Dortmund 1-0 earlier to leave Bayern a step closer to the title before it even played. Leverkusen ended Dortmund's four-game winning run and did Bayern a favor - with a warning before they meet in the semifinals of the German Cup on April 22. There were whistles for Dortmund defender Nico Schlotterbeck before and during the match after his contract extension was

announced on Friday. Dortmund fans were apparently upset that the negotiations took so long and about a tabloid report the new deal includes a release clause effective this summer for Bayern and Real Madrid. Dortmund started well and had more possession but a loss of it when Robert Andrich pounced on a loose pass from Rami Bensebaini to Fabio Silva led to the only goal in the 42nd minute. The Leverkusen defender let fly inside the left post from around 25 meters. It was enough for Leverkusen to move to fifth, a point behind Stuttgart in the last Champions League qualification spot. Stuttgart hosts Hamburger SV on Sunday. (AP)

Royal Challengers Bengaluru beat Mumbai Indians by 18 runs

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Royal Challengers Bengaluru skipper Rajat Patidar, Phil Salt and Virat Kohli blasted half-centuries as the defending champions beat Mumbai Indians by 18 runs in an Indian Premier League match here on Sunday.

Salt (78 off 36 balls) and Kohli (50 off 38 balls) stitched together a 120-run stand for the opening wicket before Patidar scored a rapid 53 off just 20 balls as RCB posted 240 for 4.

In response, Mumbai Indians were restricted to 222 for 5, with RCB spinner Suyash Sharma (2/47) putting the skids on the home side

with a double strike in the eighth over, from which they could not recover.

Sherfane Rutherford top-scored for MI with an unbeaten 71 off 31 balls.

While opener Rohit Sharma appeared to be struggling with a hamstring issue and had to retire hurt on 19, his partner Ryan Rickelton made 37, while Suryakumar Yadav (33) and Hardik Pandya (40) were the other contributors for MI.

Earlier in the game, half-centuries from the top-order troika of Virat Kohli (50), Phil Salt (78) and Rajat Patidar (53) provided the impetus as Royal Challengers Bengaluru finished with a massive 240 for four against Mumbai



Indians in their Indian Premier League match here on Sunday.

Salt and Kohli put on 120 for the first wicket while Patidar and Tim David (35 not out off 16 balls) produced rapid knocks in the second half to power the defending champions to a strong position.

The proceedings began with Kohli unleashing a spectacular flick off the pads to hit a flat six off Trent Boult over deep square leg. While Kohli kept picking the odd boundary, it was his partner Salt who took the initiative to accelerate the scoring rate.

At the start, the Englishman made room to hit fast bowlers Boult and

Hardik Pandya for boundaries.

Boult was pulled into the stands with disdain for a six, while Mitchell Santner was pummelled for three consecutive sixes when the New Zealand captain erred with his lengths.

RCB's charge - 50 came up in 4.2 overs - forced MI to bring back a wicketless Jasprit Bumrah for a second over in the powerplay which is not the norm.

The move did work as the pace ace allowed only six runs off the last over in the powerplay, but at the end RCB still were on top with 71 on board.

Salt took a liking for leg-spinner Mayank Markande in

the eighth over to smack three consecutive fours, while Kohli went after Santner's third over to hit two more.

Desperate for a breakthrough, Mumbai Indians finally turned to Shardul Thakur in the 11th over who had Salt caught by Pandya at cover for the first wicket, ending RCB's opening partnership at 120. Aided by some ordinary bowling, Patidar came close to equalling the record for fastest IPL half-century but eventually completed it off 17 balls.

He started off by lifting Shardul Thakur over cover for a four and cashed in on some poor lengths by Markande to smack the leg-

spinner for three consecutive sixes. In no time, Patidar had raced to 34 off nine.

Desperate to stop leaking runs, Mumbai deployed Thakur to bowl the wide-of-the-off deliveries but he erred more often than not in nailing those.

Salt's charge at the start followed by Patidar's blitzkrieg in the middle overs allowed Kohli to farm the strike and bring up his half-century, following which he fell for a 37-ball 50 in the 15th over.

Having given away 22 runs in his first over, Santner kept it largely tight in his remaining overs and signed off with the wicket of Patidar, who made 53 off 20 balls with five sixes and four fours.

You need to bring your body and mind to basics: Samson

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

Chennai Super Kings opener Sanju Samson said he went back to the basics after three batting failures as he set up his side's 23-run win over Delhi Capitals with an unbeaten hundred in the IPL here on Saturday.

Samson made 6, 7 and 9 in CSK's three losses in a row in the IPL 2026, before his 56-ball 115 not out, studded with 15 fours and four sixes, gave the home side their first win of the season.

"I failed a lot. Failing a lot tells you how to come back. Mentally, you think if you need to go hard or change the game-plan. You need to bring your body and mind to basics," Samson said at the



post-match presentation. "Basics are to get in a mentally different zone. We need to come back to timing the ball, and watching it come out nicely from the bowler's hand. Very happy things have come (out) nicely today," He said it was not easy to join a

new franchise — from RR to CSK this season — but the team environment has made it easy for him.

"Really means a lot. The trust they (CSK franchise) showed in me, it was a very responsible feeling that I need to put in a show and

say we are still in the tournament," said the player of the match. "Not easy to start off at a different franchise but it never felt like it. It was like coming to a second home. We just had a meeting of 50 seconds today (despite three losses) — that connects with the kind of person I am."

On his 113-run partnership with youngster Ayush Mhatre (59), he said, "Very important to have a great partnership. It never looked like he (Mhatre) was coming out of U-19 — he was so calculative. Shows the character he has." On his hundred celebration, Samson said, "That was for (Stephen) Fleming. I know how hard it can get, leading a franchise for years. Just wanted to dedicate this (innings) to Fleming." CSK

captain Rituraj Gaikwad said the team felt good to finally get the win. "Great performance. We had been batting well. To post 200-210, when wicket is on slower side, we were showing good signs. One of those knocks where Sanju took to the opposition, played a magnificent knock. Ayush also.

"But today was about the bowling. Taking wickets, bowling aggressive lengths. We do not have that X-Factor in the bowling, but we have been discussing on how to be more effective and more proactive. In the last few games, we were almost there. Some big overs cost us.

"Bowling wise, we were on the mark (tonight). We were set back in the powerplay but we came back after it."

DC captain Axar Patel said fielding was the difference in the match. "We started well but after the powerplay, we lost quick wickets and that broke the momentum. The fielding was the difference in the match. Wickets falling in clusters made it tough to regain momentum.

"Batters did a decent job but overall, our fielding was a let-down. Want to credit the bowlers, to keep them to that score, despite them having set batters on a good wicket. "A couple of dropped catches, had we taken them, it might have been different. Pitch did not change. It was a little more difficult for them (with the dew in the second innings) but they bowled pretty well," he noted.

Gill, Buttler, Prasadh guide GT to 7-wicket win over LSG



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lucknow

Skipper Shubman Gill and Jos Buttler backed up Prasadh Krishna's excellent four-wicket burst with flamboyant half-centuries, guiding Gujarat Titans to a comfortable seven-wicket win over Lucknow Super Giants in an Indian Premier League match here on Sunday.

Prasadh shone brightly with figures of 4 for 24 as GT restricted LSG to 164 for eight and then the visitors rode on Gill (56) and Buttler (60) to chase down the target with eight balls to spare. The Titans made 165 for three.

GT started brightly with Gill and Sai Sudharsan stitching 45 runs off 31 balls before the latter was dismissed by Digvesh Rathi, caught by Avesh Khan at fine leg.

Buttler grabbed with both hands the life offered to him by LSG skipper Rishabh Pant. The Englishman was dropped by the wicketkeeper off Rathi in the eighth over.

Thereafter, it was Gill and Buttler show, as the duo dis-

mantled the LSG attack with brute force. The duo shared 85 runs for the second wicket off just 58 balls and took the attack to the opposition bowlers. While Gill made 56 off 40 balls and decorated his knock with six fours and one six, Buttler returned to form with an equally well-executed fifty. But after doing all the hard work, Gill gloved a Prince Yadav bouncer to Pant while trying to pull the bowler. It was double blow for GT as Buttler departed an over later while trying to hit a slower delivery from Mohammed Shami out of the park, brilliantly caught by Aiden Markram at long-on boundary. But Washington Sundar (21 not out) and Rahul Tewatia (10 not out) anchored GT home from there.

Earlier sent into bat, Markram made 30 off 21 balls, but Mitchell Marsh (11), Pant (18) and Ayush Badoni (9) failed to live up to the expectations. Markram started on a bright note, finding the fence at will from the word go and decorated his innings with five boundaries and one six. Marsh also started brightly, welcoming Kagiso Rabada with a six and boundary before falling in the next ball in search of one too many big hits — caught by GT skipper Gill at mid-off. New man in Pant started his knock with a boundary through mid-off.

Markram, though, continued his attacking game finding the fence at will, LSG were dealt a body blow when Pant was dismissed by Mohammed Siraj in the fifth over.

Sawan Barwal breaks Shivnath Singh's 48-year-old marathon national record



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Rotterdam (Netherlands)

Long-distance runner Sawan Barwal on Sunday scripted history by breaking the 48-year-old marathon national record, the longest standing mark in Indian athletics, at the NN Marathon Rotterdam.

Barwal clocked 2 hours 11 minutes and 58 seconds in a world class field to finish 20th in the elite marathon race and erase the previous national record of 2:12:00 which stood since 1978 in Shivnath Singh's name.

The other Indian in the fray, Gopi Thonakal finished 23rd as he ran the 42.195km distance with a time of 2:13:16.

Barwal's achievement was all the more praiseworthy as the Rotterdam event was his first marathon race. He had not run any official marathon race before Sunday.

This was his second competition of the season after taking part in the World Athletics Cross Country Championships in the USA in January. Hailing from a village in Joginder Nagar in Mandi district of Himachal Pradesh, the 28-year-old Barwal has trained hard for many years, establishing himself as a

reputed long-distance runner. His feat on Sunday was the culmination of that hard work, as he literally emerged from the hills of Himachal Pradesh to the flat roads of Rotterdam.

Barwal ran at a steady pace in the gruelling race but windy conditions in the last 5km took a toll on the Indian runner. "It was pretty cold and windy. I made a mistake of pouring water on my head at the water station," Barwal said. "I was running at a comfortable pace until the 37km mark. But the last 2km was more challenging as I had to just plod to cross the finish line. "I was mentally and physically prepared to clock 2:10:00. But tough conditions robbed me of further improving my national record." The Army runner fell down after crossing the finish line due to exhaustion. He was taken for medical assistance. "I've recovered and am feeling better," he added.

Barwal, an Armyman, was at the 27th spot at around the halfway mark (21km) with a time of 1:04:43 while Gopi was 33rd with 1:04:44. At the 30km mark, he was below the 2:10:00 marathon pace.

Delhi's Aarit becomes youngest Indian IM

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Delhi-based 10-year-old Aarit Kapil became the youngest Indian chess player to make an International Master norm after he drew with Samuel Asaka of Australia in the final round of an international tournament at Menorca in Spain.

After a brilliant start that included a victory over former world under-20 champion and Grandmaster Nogerbek Kazybek of Kazakhstan in the second round, Aarit, who is just 10 years and seven months old, became the youngest Indian to hold an IM norm.

Stepping into the shoes of ace Indians like D Gukesh,



Arjun and Praggnanandhaa might be some time away, but with his sheer talent Aarit has shown that he could be the next big thing in Indian chess with his performance

in Spain. Winning the under-11 national championship last year was a turning point for the young Delhiite and he has taken it forward in a big way. He is currently ranked number two in the

RR manager uses phone in dugout

KUSHAN SARKAR
■ New Delhi

Rajasthan Royals' long-time team manager Romi Bhinder has courted controversy after TV cameras caught him using a mobile phone in the team dugout during their IPL match against Royal Challengers Bengaluru.

The incident was first shared on Instagram by a social media influencer but it has been ascertained that Bhinder was indeed using a mobile phone with teen sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi sitting beside him during the Royals' six-wicket win in Guwahati on Friday. "Yes, Bhinder has indeed breached the protocol of Players and Match Officials Area (PMOA) as cell phones are banned in the dugout during match," a BCCI official confirmed. On IPL's official



website, the concerned clause regarding PMOA protocol 2026 states: "The Team Manager may use a phone in the dressing room but NOT in the dugout."

People in the know feel that Bhinder, who has been associated with the franchise since its inception, was expected to be fully aware of the anti-corruption protocols. "It could be inadvertent

but there has to be some action since it amounts to breach. Whether it will be warning or match ban will depend on match referee and ACU report. Based on that IPL GC can take a call," the senior official said. Bhinder could face closer scrutiny, especially after Sooryavanshi referred to him as his "local guardian" during the post-match presentation.

Rana fined match fee for arguing with umpire

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

Delhi Capitals batter Nitish Rana has been fined 25 per cent of his match fee for an intense altercation with the fourth umpire during their Indian Premier League match against Chennai Super Kings here.

The incident occurred in the 19th over when umpire denied Tristan Stubbs' request to change his wet gloves, leading to a heated dispute. Stubbs asked to change his gloves due to heavy perspiration in Chennai's humidity on Saturday. After his dismissal, a frustrated Rana confronted the fourth umpire for which he was also handed a demerit point. "Nitish Rana,



batter, Delhi Capitals has been fined 25 per cent of his match fee and has also accumulated 1 demerit point for breaching Level 1 of the IPL's Code of Conduct for Players," IPL said in a statement.

"Rana was found to have breached article 2.3 of the IPL's Code of Conduct, which relates to 'use of an audible

obscenity during a match'," the statement added.

Rana admitted to the offence and accepted the Match Referee's sanction.

Gaikwad fined ₹12 lakh for slow over-rate: Chennai Super Kings captain Ruturaj Gaikwad was fined Rs 12 lakh after his side maintained a slow over-rate against Delhi Capitals.

CSK opened their account in this IPL with a 23-run win over Delhi Capitals at the MA Chidambaram Stadium here on Saturday.

"As this was his team's first offence of the season under Article 2.22 of the IPL's Code of Conduct, which pertains to minimum over-rate offences, Gaikwad was fined INR 12 lakhs," said the IPL media advisory.

Three hours of bad tennis hurt us: Uppal

AMANPREET SINGH
■ New Delhi

India captain Vishal Uppal lamented "three hours of bad tennis" on the opening day as the decisive factor behind the team missing out on qualification for World Group Play-offs as the hosts signed off with a third-place finish in Asia/Oceania Group I of the Billie Jean King Cup, here.



India will stay in Group I as the top two teams — Thailand and Indonesia — sealed qualification. Reflecting on a week of fluctuating fortunes, Uppal said the slow start against Thailand proved costly in a tightly-contested competition. "The high is obviously that we beat Korea. The low is the fact that we played three hours of bad tennis at the start of the week, which has cost us.

RR's juggernaut takes on under-pressure SRH

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Hyderabad

A rampant Rajasthan Royals will look to tighten their grip on the top spot when they face an inconsistent Sunrisers Hyderabad in an Indian Premier League clash here on Monday.

The Royals have been the standout side this season, ticking almost every box with



authority. Four commanding wins in as many games have underlined their dominance, powered by a destructive top

order and a vastly improved bowling attack.

At the heart of their success is the explosive opening pair of Yashasvi Jaiswal and teen sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, who have consistently dismantled opposition attacks in the Powerplay.

Jaiswal's elegance combined with Sooryavanshi's fearless strokeplay have made them one of the most feared

duos this season.

At number three, Dhruv Jurel has added stability, stitching partnerships and ensuring the early momentum is not lost. The middle order, led by skipper Riyan Parag, remains largely untested, though it has not maximised the limited chances it has got so far, perhaps the only minor concern in an otherwise dominant campaign.